

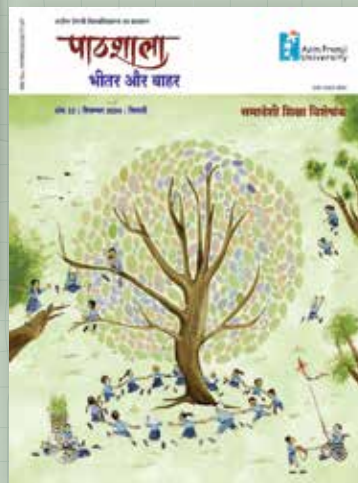
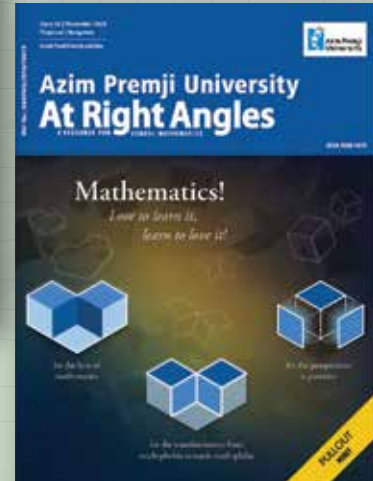
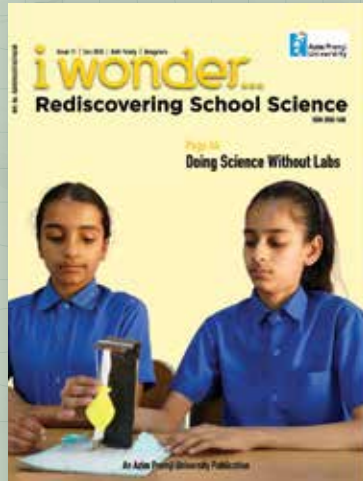
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Will foreign languages survive the CBSE directive?

Muskaan Sehgal

A policy circular or newspaper headline announced the shift of a foreign language curriculum as “optional”, which left students, teachers and parents with many unanswered questions about their careers and aspirations. Muskaan Sehgal writes about what the CBSE’s new directive means for the future of language learning in India.

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Editor

Usha Raman

Editorial Team

Shalini B

Sushma Rana

Engagement Editor

Shruti Singhal

Layout & Graphics

Rajendra Kumar S

RNI Publications Consultant

K Raghurama Raju

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A 15, Vikramপুরi, Secunderabad 500 009. Telangana. India. Mobile: 89779 42097 editorial@teacherplus.org www.teacherplus.org

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Cover: Playing with language

Designed by **Padmasri**, a visual storyteller who loves turning small memories and everyday experiences into illustrations. She is drawn to quiet emotions, meaningful details, and the warmth of childhood. Whether she is illustrating a book or a magazine, she hopes her work leaves people with a sense of comfort, curiosity, and connection. The illustrator can be reached at [<padmasripattabi@gmail.com>](mailto:padmasripattabi@gmail.com).



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Keeping hope alive



I'm sure many of you will agree that this has been quite a month. There's not much I can say that has not already been said across all kinds of media, from individually run social media accounts to the largest print and audiovisual outlets. No matter which side of the ideological divide one might be on, there's no denying that something has shifted in how we think about young people and politics. For a while now, many adults, particularly those of us who grew up in a pre-internet/social media age, have dismissed younger generations as being too disconnected, too immersed in their own worlds, and too amenable to the seductions of the online in its various forms. We used terms like "slacktivism" and "clicktivism" to characterize their attempts to participate in online calls to action, and we've shrugged off the pervasive meme culture as trivial, even laughable. But the recent protests at Jantar Mantar and elsewhere have showed us that young people have the will, the energy, and the wherewithal, to make a point with humour and turn it into something that has the power to mobilize and change minds. Many of the young protestors were barely out of high school, some accompanied by parents and young siblings, but all willing to go out on a limb to demand a better deal from those who govern their worlds.

So, how might we respond to the multiple anxieties that children may be bringing to the final years of schooling? We are in what many call a "polycrisis" – governance failure, disruptive technologies, climate change, and growing inequality. I've often spoken of the classroom as a transformative space, yet here we are, at a moment when individual or community-level change appears ineffective in the face of a dysfunctional system.

As school teachers, we may be removed from these demands, and have little to do with the issues at the core of the current movement, as many of them relate to higher education. Yet it's hard to deny that school education is the backstory to higher ed, and much of our efforts – at least in classes 9 through 12 – are directed at readying students to be good enough at test taking to crack the entry to college, professional, vocational, or otherwise. When it becomes clear that no amount of preparation is going to ensure that entry, it seems to render everything somewhat meaningless. The anger and frustration that erupted into the recent protests was a response to that; not just one paper leak or one mis-managed assessment, but a sense that no matter how hard one works, it's hard to beat a corrupt system. But the protests did show us that hope can be kept alive when we come together and express ourselves through music, art, literature, and yes, humour.

This is what the valiant contributors to *Teacher Plus* try to do, by sharing their experiences of keeping the hope of education alive, month after month. For example – by finding ways to make math "humane" as our columnist Monika Kochar does. By offering insights into how we might keep inter-generational communication going, as Neerja Singh does. By building context into language learning, as Sanjhee Gianchandani does. Or by bringing the wisdom of Kabir to season our understanding of the world, as Pradita Nambiar describes.

We'd love to know how you keep hope alive.

Usha Rana

Will foreign languages survive the CBSE directive?

Muskaan Sehgal

For six years, I never questioned whether I had chosen the right profession. Every morning, I walked into my French classroom feeling fortunate. I wasn't just teaching a language; I was opening a window to another world. Teaching was never just a job for me. It was a privilege. Not everyone gets to spend their days doing something they genuinely love.

Then, one morning, as I sat with my usual cup of *chai* and unfolded the newspaper, a headline stopped me cold.

"Sudden rollout of CBSE's three-language mandate stumps Class 9 students in NCR."

I read it twice. Then I sat with it for a long time.

That morning, something shifted. For the first time in my career, I could not see a future.

I am not alone in this feeling. Across India, thousands of foreign language teachers woke up to the same headline. They felt the same thing – that in one circular, years of dedication, of weekend lesson planning, of staying late to help a



Illustrations: Sunil Chawdiker

struggling student with their oral practice, had been rendered invisible. Not wrong. Not ineffective. Just irrelevant.

What struck me most keenly was not the policy itself. It was the image that kept returning: an Indian child, years from now, travelling to Paris, or Tokyo, or Barcelona – curious, eager, bright – but equipped with little more than a few facts about the country, unable to hold a conversation with its people. We had the chance to give that child a language. A key. A way to make their country proud simply by being able to say, in someone else's tongue, *"I understand you."*

That chance is now at risk.

I thought about colleagues who had spent years building foreign language departments from scratch, collecting storybooks from different parts of the world, preparing students for DELF (a French language diploma exam) and other equivalent examinations, convincing parents that learning another language mattered. Overnight, many of them were wondering whether their subject would even exist.

I thought about the students who had once told me they wanted to study in France, become chefs, work in diplomacy, or simply watch a French film without subtitles. They hadn't chosen French because someone told them to. They chose it because it made the world feel bigger.

That morning, I realized this was no longer just a policy debate. It had entered my classroom and the lives of my students and colleagues. And that is the story I want to tell.

The directive that changed our classrooms

On 15 May 2026, the Central Board of Secondary Education issued Circular No. Acad-33/2026. The directive was straightforward, but its implications were not. From 1 July 2026, all class 9 students must study three languages – R1, R2, and R3 – with at least two being native Indian languages. Foreign languages such as French, German, Spanish, and Japanese could now only be studied as a third language if the other two were Indian, or as an optional fourth.

What made this particularly disorienting was the timing. The circular arrived three months into the academic year. Timetables had already been set. Students had been promoted. Teachers had been assigned. And schools were now being asked to restructure everything by 30 June.

The ground-level response was immediate. In Kolkata, several CBSE schools shutdown French classes entirely and began implementing Sanskrit. In Noida, a renowned school distributed class 6 Sanskrit textbooks to existing class 9 students – an interim measure that captured, better than any policy document, just how unprepared the system was. One Delhi school sent parents a notice informing them that French and German would continue as additional languages but would no longer be included in any examination. With a single circular, a subject that children had studied for years had been reclassified as a hobby.

A class 8 student messaged me a day after the circular, "Ma'am... will there still be French next year?"

On 29 June 2026, CBSE issued a press release offering partial relief. Students already in classes 7, 8, and 9 who had been studying two non-Indian languages could continue with those languages and simply add one Indian language as R3. Class 10 students faced no change at all. The relief was real – but it was also temporary. For students entering class 6 from 2026 onwards, two of the three languages had to be Indian. When this batch reaches class 10, they will face a board examination in that third language. The window for foreign language education in CBSE schools is not closing all at once. It is narrowing, quietly, one batch at a time.

A teacher from a Delhi school put it plainly in a teachers' group that has become a gathering point for hundreds of anxious educators across the country: *"This relief is only for two to three years. After that, we will be in the same situation."*

She was right. And everyone in that group knew it.

A formula born from complexity

The Three-Language Formula did not emerge overnight. In 1964, the National Education Commission – commonly known as the Kothari Commission – was tasked with reimagining India's education system for a newly independent linguistically diverse nation. Two years later, it proposed a framework that would attempt to hold together a country of hundreds of tongues: every student would study their regional language or mother tongue, Hindi for students in non-Hindi-speaking states or another Indian language for those in Hindi-speaking states, and English or another modern European language as the third.

The Indian government adopted this as part of the National Policy on Education in 1968. The ambition was clear – promote national integration, preserve regional identity, and equip Indians for global participation. The reality, however, was far more complicated.

In government schools and Kendriya Vidyalayas, the formula found some footing. In urban private schools, implementation was uneven at best. In northern India, the typical structure became Hindi as the first language, Sanskrit or a regional language as the second, and English as the third, with a European language sometimes offered as an optional fourth. In southern India, schools generally followed a pattern of regional language, Hindi, and English. Tamil Nadu, however, was always the exception.

Tamil Nadu – a resistance rooted in history

Of all India's states, Tamil Nadu's opposition to the Three-Language Formula is the oldest, the most consistent, and perhaps the most deeply felt.

The roots go back to 1937, when the then Madras Presidency government attempted to make Hindi compulsory in schools, triggering protests that

lasted two years. In 1965, anti-Hindi agitations erupted again across Tamil Nadu, resulting in nearly 70 deaths and forcing the central government to guarantee that English would remain an associate official language alongside Hindi. These are not distant memories in Tamil Nadu – they are part of the state's living political identity.

Tamil Nadu has maintained a two-language policy – Tamil and English – in its schools since the 1960s, and shows no signs of changing course. The state formally rejected NEP 2020, with the state assembly passing a resolution against it, citing concerns about the Three-Language Formula and what it perceived as centralization of education policy. Many in Tamil Nadu argue that mandating Hindi – a language that Hindi-speaking students need not learn as a foreign tongue – creates a structural disadvantage for non-Hindi speakers in national examinations and public life. Language policy, the state insists, is a state subject. Central directives on the matter are seen not as guidance but as overreach.

From conversations to collective action

The conversations did not end with anxious messages. As the uncertainty continued, teachers began organizing late-night Google Meets that often stretched into the wee hours. Some shared updates from lawyers. Others discussed possible career alternatives if foreign languages gradually disappeared from schools. A few tried to reassure younger teachers who had only recently entered the profession, while others admitted they had no answers themselves. The discussions moved constantly between hope and despair, with every rumour, news report, or court update sending fresh waves of speculation through the group.

Soon, the conversations turned into action. A meeting was organized for 24 May, followed by a peaceful visit to the CBSE office in Dwarka on 1 June – described carefully not as a protest, but a respectful request for dialogue and solution. Teachers were encouraged to bring at least five parents each, because by then everyone understood that this was no longer only about the future of foreign language teachers. It was about students who had already invested years in learning another language, and families who suddenly found themselves navigating uncertainty without clear answers.

What stayed with me was the message that appeared subsequently. The turnout was far smaller than everyone had hoped. One organiser wrote with quiet



disappointment: "It is difficult to understand why many of those directly affected are still not coming forward. We are fighting not only for ourselves but for everyone."

That message stayed with me long after I read it. Because in those weeks, I came to understand that the greatest challenge was not only the policy itself or the uncertainty surrounding it. It was the feeling that an entire community of teachers, students, and parents was searching for its voice – while decisions about the future of language education were already being made around them, and without them.

When the matter reached the Supreme Court

For many teachers, waiting was no longer an option. As schools began implementing the circular and uncertainty spread through classrooms, the frustration on the ground eventually reached the Supreme Court of India.

In late May 2026, a petition was filed – *Yashica Bhandari Jain and Others v. Union of India and Others, W.P. (Civil) No. 694/2026* – by a group of 19 parents and teachers from Delhi, Gurugram, Noida, and Chennai, challenging the CBSE circular. The petition argued that the policy had been introduced in the middle of an active academic cycle, that students had already been promoted under the previous framework, and that schools had neither the teachers nor the textbooks to implement the change smoothly. Most significantly, it highlighted that permanent foreign language teachers were being asked to resign mid-session or reassign themselves to other subjects entirely.

The Supreme Court issued a notice to the union government, CBSE, and NCERT, and posted the matter for hearing in the second week of July. The Bench observed that the core question may not be one of federalism but of reasonableness – specifically, whether a policy can be enforced when the basic infrastructure to support it does not as yet exist. As of writing, no stay was granted. The case remains pending.

Voices from the classroom

The statistics and court proceedings tell one part of this story. The human reality is another.

Nidhi Kaushal, a French teacher from Delhi, shared what many in her position are feeling. "I am close to 50. I started a French language course at the age of 37 from Delhi University, inspired by my son. Right now, I am doing my MA in French from IGNOU.

With the confusion and drama created by CBSE, I am at a stage where nothing is going in a positive direction. How am I going to deliver my knowledge to the next generation? Should I leave French? Should I switch to my basic subjects? I am waiting for a response – for all of us in foreign language teaching."

Nidhi is not alone in that wait. Across the country, teachers who have spent years – sometimes decades – building their expertise in a language are now being asked to consider whether that expertise still has a place.

Sarmistha Ganguli, an ELT specialist and language assessor, put the policy's deeper flaw plainly: "It is sad to see such a regressive policy. Children should learn compulsory Indian languages till class 8 and from class 9 they need to make their choices. None of the schools are going to hire any new teacher for any Indian language – it will just revolve around Hindi and Sanskrit. Anything adopted because of outside pressure will be chaotic, mismanaged, and without authenticity. If it is really about authenticity, then a list of state languages should have been given and textbooks prescribed."

Hamid Hussain, a Spanish and German educator, offered a perspective that cuts to the heart of what is at stake: "This is not just about a policy shift. It is about the human cost of abrupt implementation. Language learning builds cultural bridges, global perspectives, and cognitive growth. While promoting Indian languages is important, transitions of this scale deserve thoughtful planning, proper resources, and most importantly, consultation with educators who have dedicated years to this field. Students, teachers, and schools deserve clarity, preparation time, and respect for the work already invested."

And then there was Anjali Gautam, a fellow teacher, who wrote something in one of those late-night WhatsApp groups that I have not been able to forget: "I know how painful it is to know that you're losing your job for no fault of your own. And on top of that, the students are suffering so much. I don't know how they expect students to cope with this."

That last line – *I don't know how they expect students to cope* – is the question I keep returning to.

Whenever I think about this debate, I don't immediately think about policy documents or court hearings. I think about my students. A child in class 6 this year, beginning French with enthusiasm, has

no idea that by the time she reaches class 10, the landscape of language education in her school may look entirely different. She is not in any WhatsApp group. She is not filing a petition. She is simply learning – trusting that the system around her is stable. As I began speaking to the students, I realized they were thinking far beyond examinations. Several of these voices came from class 9 students and parents at Manav Rachna International School, Gurugram – one of many schools where this debate is quietly playing out. Taesha Dhawan, a student who has studied French since class 5, told me that learning the language had never felt disconnected from her future. As a trained western dancer hoping to study internationally one day, she saw French as preparation for the life she wanted to build. When the new policy was announced, what unsettled her most was the thought that "a subject we cared about could be put at risk." She added, "I would feel it is a significant loss if future students are not given the option to choose a language like French at all."

Anshika Ahuja came to French language learning differently. She chose it in class 5 in part because her aunt has been teaching French in Delhi for the past 20 years, and her parents were confident from the start that she'd pick it – they knew, she said, that French could open doors internationally. What started as something close to a family expectation has since turned into her own interest. "With every year, I am getting more and more aligned towards this language," she told me, and she's now considering French as a career, partly because of how many well-known universities are based there.

Anaya Kehar chose French because she wanted to explore a new language, and because she hopes it will help her study fashion in Paris one day. She sees the policy as a matter of rights, not just preference: "We have the right to speak, write, or learn in any language we choose," she said, pointing to Article 19. If students lose the ability to choose a foreign language, she believes they lose the chance to step outside what's familiar to them – and, with it, access to opportunities in international business.

Her mother, Saloni Kehar, was more concerned about what the policy asks of a class 9 student day-to-day. "Juggling an additional Indian language alongside an already demanding core syllabus creates immense pressure and academic burnout," she said. She wasn't arguing against Hindi or the regional languages – she said she respects their value – but she wanted CBSE to consider what a mandatory third

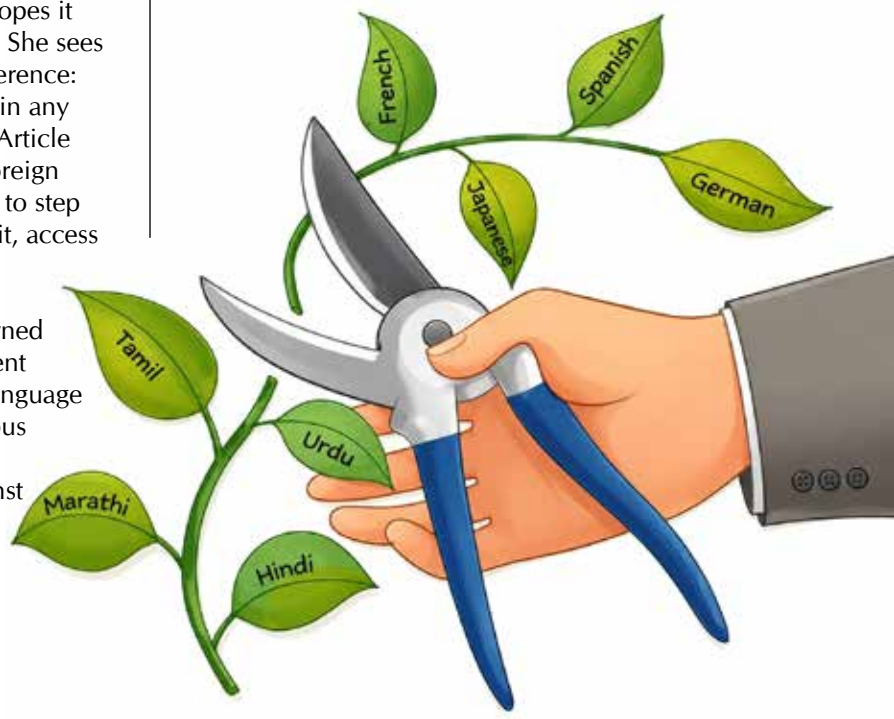
language does to students who are already stretched thin, and to their ability to focus on what matters most to them.

Another student, Anahita Sharma, reflected that learning French had taught her patience, introduced her to another culture, and shown her that languages open doors to future opportunities. For her, the issue was simple: "Every student should have the freedom to learn a language of their choice."

As a teacher with over six years of teaching French across CBSE schools in Delhi, I have watched this debate unfold not from a distance, but from inside a classroom. I have seen firsthand how foreign language teachers are often treated as peripheral – secondary to the "main" subject teachers, their work considered less serious, their students' choices less valid. Foreign languages have largely been offered in CBSE schools from classes 6 to 9, just enough to give students a taste, but rarely with the institutional commitment to help them go further. Even when students wanted to continue, the system rarely supported them.

What this policy has done is simply make that reality official.

Not one of my students chose French because it was fashionable. They chose it because it opened a window to a different world – a curiosity, a confidence, a way of seeing beyond what they already knew. I still don't know what language some of my future students will be allowed to choose. I don't know what classrooms like mine will look like five years from now. But I do know this: every child



UPDATE: On July 14, 2026, the Supreme Court declined to stay CBSE's three-language policy for the 2026-27

academic year, with Chief Justice Surya Kant remarking that "learning a language never goes to waste." However, CBSE has indicated that the requirement to study two Indian languages will apply only to students entering class 6 going forward, not retroactively to those already in classes 7-9. The Court also assured that it would step in if any teacher faced dismissal for non-compliance during the transition. The matter was listed for further hearing on July 22; the outcome of that hearing is yet to be confirmed in reports.

deserves the opportunity to discover a language because it sparks something in them – not because policy happened to leave the door open.

A way forward

When I first read that headline, I thought I was reading about the future of foreign languages in CBSE schools. Over the weeks that followed, as I spoke to teachers, parents, school leaders, and students, I realized the story was much larger than one language or one circular.

At its heart, this is a conversation about what kind of education we want for our children.

India has never struggled with multilingualism. It lives in our homes, our streets, our classrooms, and our everyday conversations. Walk into almost any classroom, and you will find children effortlessly moving between languages – speaking one at home, another with friends, and a third in school. Our diversity has never needed proof. What it has always needed is thoughtful support.

During my conversations for this article, Rayon Dhawan, whose daughter Taesha has studied French since class 5, told me that what began as another school subject gradually became part of his daughter's future aspirations. "French became more than just a school subject," he wrote. "It became preparation for the international path she hopes to build." When the circular was announced, his greatest concern was how quickly "a subject a child truly loves can be taken out of their hands." He believes students deserve the freedom to choose the language that genuinely supports their aspirations.

His concern was not about foreign languages. It was about whether our education system is evolving with the world our children will inherit.

Every parent I have spoken to asks some version of the same question: *Will this help my child grow? Will it prepare them for the future?* Those questions deserve answers grounded not only in policy, but in pedagogy, planning, and the realities of classrooms.

Anubha Srivastava, Principal of Delhi International School Edge in Dwarka, perhaps put it best: "Our objective should not be multilingualism by compulsion, but multilingualism through competence, curiosity and choice." It is a distinction that the current implementation, in its haste, has not yet found a way to honour.

Promoting Indian languages is a meaningful and necessary goal. Our linguistic heritage deserves to be celebrated and preserved. But meaningful multilingual education cannot be built through hurried implementation alone. It requires trained teachers, appropriate resources, adequate transition time, and above all, conversations with the educators and students who will live with these decisions every day.

A child who learns French does not become less Indian. She becomes an Indian who can speak to more people, understand another culture, and carry her own identity with greater confidence. The same is true of a child learning Tamil, Sanskrit, Bengali, or Japanese. Every language a child learns is not a step away from who they are – it is a step further into who they can become.

Policies will change. Circulars will be revised. Court cases will eventually reach their conclusion. But I hope we never lose sight of the child sitting quietly in the classroom, discovering a language for the very first time. Curiosity is one of the greatest gifts that education can nurture. Whatever languages our schools choose to teach, I hope we continue to protect that curiosity.

That is the classroom I still hope to walk into every morning.

Muskaan Sehgal is a Delhi-based French language educator and freelance writer with over six years of experience in language teaching, curriculum development, and Cambridge programme coordination across CBSE schools. She writes on education, language policy, and classroom practice. The author can be reached at <muskaanmehta803@gmail.com>.

Teaching of three languages

The Arunachal perspective

K. Rajendra Babu

Arunachal Pradesh, known as the Land of the Rising Sun, is situated in the north-east corner of India, strategically bordering China, Bhutan, and Myanmar. This state is predominantly inhabited by 26 major tribes and around 100 minor tribes, each having its distinct culture, tradition, language, and custom. When the erstwhile NEFA ([North East Frontier Agency](#)), then a part of Assam, became the union territory of Arunachal Pradesh, the official language of the state and the medium of instruction in all its educational institutions changed from Assamese to English in 1972. But, the Arunachali people continued to use Assamese and later Hindi as the lingua franca with fewer and fewer people conversing in their respective languages/dialects. It is only in the last five years that a serious attempt has begun at the government and community levels to bring Arunachali languages into the school curriculum.

The first school in Arunachal Pradesh was established in 1918 by the British in Pasighat. Today, there are 2850ⁱ schools in the state, all of which, whether government or private, are affiliated to the CBSE as the state does not have its own education board.

i. <https://education.arunachal.gov.in/statistics/schools>



It is only in the last five years that a serious attempt has begun at the government and community levels to bring Arunachali languages into the school curriculum.



NEP 2020 and the Three Language Formula

Under NEP 2020, a Three Language Formula has been envisaged with the objective of promoting multilingualism, preserving regional linguistic heritage, fostering national integration, and enhancing cognitive development, while offering flexible language choices without imposing any specific language.

The CBSE has now taken a decision to implement the Three Language Formula from the current academic session, i.e., 2026-27. Out of the three languages, two have to be Bharatiya Bhashas – R1 and R2 (from the [22 scheduled Indian languages](#)). R1 is the mother tongue or home language and R2 (another Bharatiya Bhasha) and R3 can be English or any other foreign language. The current batch of class 6 students have to continue with the chosen set of languages till they appear for their Board examination in class 10 in 2029-30.

The Arunachal scenario

In Arunachal Pradesh, all government and private schools have been teaching three languages for the last few decades, with English and Hindi from classes 1 to 10, and Assamese or Sanskrit as the third language in classes 6 to 8. The choice of the third language was then wholly based on the availability of teachers in that particular school or district. With the teaching and learning of the third language being restricted to just three years, it received only minimal pedagogic attention in school education and planning. Most parents, the local elite, and students who have been through this language learning phase, have felt that learning a third language is of little practical use in their future life – academic or public.

But with the state leaders and local community organizations waking up to the idea of teaching Arunachali mother languages in primary and middle schools, the state government has recently decided to introduce Arunachali mother languages as the third



CBSE's decision to continue with the third language up to class 10 will pose many learning and teaching challenges in Arunachal schools.



language across the stateⁱⁱ. Accordingly, during the last two or three years, elementary level language textbooks have been prepared by the state SCERT in many Arunachali languages, roping in language experts of Community Based Organizations. For some languages, either the script or the books are yet to be finalized. Hence, in those districts/areas, Assamese or Sanskrit continues to be taught as the third language from class 6.

In the districts where Arunachali language books have been developed, the textbooks suitable and relevant for classes 1 and 2 are being taught in classes 6 and 7. Many linguists and local language experts, however, feel that this could be a mismatch. They wonder how apt these books are for adolescents and whether the books will be able to stimulate their interest in enhancing their mother language proficiency.

In the present circumstances, CBSE's decision to continue with the third language up to class 10 will pose many learning and teaching challenges in Arunachal schools. According to some teachers and language experts, the textbooks in local languages are at present inadequate in terms of content and it will be a difficult task preparing the textbooks leading up to class 10 in a satisfactory manner. Grammar books and dictionaries for many of the tribal languages are not yet available or have not been finalized. Due to this, teaching and learning mother languages in a formal manner in classrooms has

ii. Even though the Arunachali languages enjoy the status of R1 being the mother language, since they did not/do not have an officially accepted script, they are being taught as R3 as decided by the state SCERT. No Arunachali language is listed under the list of Scheduled Languages by NCERT.

become a difficult task. Teaching a spoken language in the same manner as languages with script not only needs imaginative development of lessons, but also requires trained teachers, grammar books, dictionaries, and other supporting supplementary reading materials. Most of these do not exist as of now.

Another difficulty in Arunachal schools would be the presence of students of different tribes and communities in a class. Hence, there will also be an administrative difficulty in teaching their respective mother languages, because teachers will not be available to teach every mother language.

A similar problem is faced by Nagaland. The principals of CBSE affiliated schools in Nagaland have urged the Union Education Minister to grant them a special linguistic exemption or a flexible framework, conveying their **difficulty in implementing the compulsory** three language policy as the state is home to over 17 major recognized tribes and several sub-tribes each with their own distinct language and oral tradition.

The way ahead

Considering all the factors, it can be concluded that though the teaching of the mother language, Hindi, and English is possible in Arunachal Pradesh, there will be several practical problems in implementing it in the present format. Hence, the CBSE should permit states like Arunachal that have several minor script-less languages, to adopt a language policy with the provision to teach the local tribal language from class 1 onwards. In the case of Arunachal Pradesh, this will be the best way to strengthen educational standards as well as promote mother language literacy.

Dr K. Rajendra Babu retired from service as Associate Professor of Commerce from Indira Gandhi Government College, Tezu, Lohit District, Arunachal Pradesh. He continues to be interested in the educational aspects of the students of Arunachal Pradesh. The author can be reached at < krajenbabu@gmail.com >.

History on foot

Priyanka Soman

There comes a point in many classrooms when one can almost sense an unspoken question hovering in the air: “Will this come for the exam?”

It is usually asked with complete sincerity – and only mild despair.

One cannot blame the students for it. History, as it is often presented, has long been reduced to a memory exercise involving kings with similar names, battles with difficult spellings, and dates that seem to evaporate soon after the answer sheet is submitted.

Somewhere in this process, history quietly loses its pulse.

Yet, history, at its heart, is not about memorizing information. It is about learning how to think with evidence.

As teachers, what do we hope students truly gain from history?

We certainly want them to read and understand concepts. But beyond that, we hope they learn to observe carefully, question confidently, make connections meaningfully, and build explanations based on evidence rather than assumption.

We want them to recognize that every historical account carries perspective. That societies in different

Illustration: Shilpy Lather

A stylized illustration of a field of tall, green grass with some darker green blades. In the upper right, a white speech bubble contains the text "INTERESTING NOBODY LABELLED IT FOR THE EXAMS!".

INTERESTING
NOBODY LABELLED
IT FOR THE
EXAMS!

periods thought differently, organized life differently, and solved problems differently. And that change over time is not random – it is layered, complex, and deeply human.

Most importantly, we hope that history develops empathy and imagination: the ability to step into another time without immediately judging it through present-day certainty.

This shifts the purpose of history education entirely.

The question is no longer: “How much content has been completed?”

It becomes: “How deeply has thinking been developed?”

This is where experiential learning – what we may loosely call a “history trip” – becomes meaningful.

Not a school outing with a checklist of sites. Not an excursion where the memory of snacks outlasts the memory of what was seen.

A meaningful history journey begins much before the travel itself.

Students read about geography, trade routes, migration, architecture, belief systems, and everyday life. They encounter history not as isolated facts but as connected human experiences. They examine maps, discuss traveller accounts, watch visual material, and importantly, ask questions that do not always have fixed answers.

Even this preparation changes their relationship with knowledge. They begin entering history with curiosity rather than the expectation of “right answers”.

Then comes the experience itself. And something subtle shifts.

A student who has read about maritime trade begins to realize that spices were not merely kitchen ingredients. They were part of networks that connected distant societies, shaped economies, and influenced political decisions. Suddenly, pepper and



cardamom are no longer ordinary objects – they become evidence of global movement.

A temple corridor, often walked through casually, begins to reveal layers of craftsmanship, labour organization, mathematics, and cultural continuity. A place of worship is also seen as a space of social history, artistic expression, and community life.

Students begin noticing things differently. Worn stone steps are no longer just old surfaces, they are records of repeated human presence. A faded carving becomes a question: who made this, and why? A restored structure raises another question: what is preserved, and what is forgotten?

At this point, students naturally begin to shift roles – from learners of information to interpreters of evidence.

Sometimes, they resemble detectives. Sometimes, simply careful observers trying to make sense of fragments.

And occasionally, they behave like philosophers – asking why certain histories are remembered while others fade quietly away.

There is also humour in these moments, often unintended.

A group of students may listen intently to discussions of ancient trade networks until someone mentions food, at which point historical attention suddenly becomes significantly sharper. It appears that curiosity, in education, is sometimes closely linked to lunch breaks.

Another recurring moment is the discovery that historical figures were not abstract names, but human beings dealing with uncertainty, logistics, ambition, and occasional confusion – much like everyone else. Empires may have been grand, but administration was still administration.

These moments make history less distant and more relatable.

But beyond humour lies something more important.

Such experiences train students in intellectual discipline.

They learn to observe carefully, document thoughtfully, compare perspectives, and construct

arguments based on evidence. They begin to understand that historical narratives are often incomplete, sometimes contradictory, and always shaped by interpretation.

This is particularly important in a time when quick conclusions are often valued more than careful thinking.

By the end of such learning experiences, the most meaningful outcomes are often not answers, but questions.

Students begin to ask:

- Why do some histories get recorded and others disappear?
- How do we know what we know about the past?
- What changes over time – and what quietly continues?
- Who gets to tell the story?

And perhaps more importantly, they begin to realize that uncertainty is not a weakness in learning – it is its starting point.

At the heart of it, history stops being “the past”.

It becomes a way of understanding human experience.

Perhaps that is the real strength of teaching history well. It does not merely tell students what happened. It helps them understand how to think about what happened. It develops patience with complexity, comfort with ambiguity, and sensitivity towards multiple perspectives.

It also reminds teachers of something equally important: that students are capable of far deeper thinking than we sometimes assume – provided they are given the space to explore rather than only instructions to recall.

If students leave a history experience with more questions than they began with, then learning has not failed.

It has only begun.

Priyanka Soman is an educator and writer with a keen interest in integrating the arts, sciences, and storytelling to create meaningful learning experiences. The author can be reached at <cspriyankaa@gmail.com>.

Chemistry in ancient Bharat – a journey of rediscovery

Yuvraj Srivastav

Rasavidya vina naiva siddhih kvapi hi jivane, tasmāt tam abhyaset prajñāh sivarthaṁ muktisadhanam.
– Rasaratna Samuccaya, Chapter 1, verse 3

"Without the knowledge of chemistry (rasavidya), success in life is not possible; therefore, the wise should study it, for it is the means to both worldly welfare and spiritual liberation."

This verse stayed with me from the moment I read it. It reflects how deeply ancient India valued chemistry – not merely as a science of elements, but as a sacred force that connected wellbeing, health, and spirituality.

Igniting curiosity through cultural science

Ancient India was a fertile ground of inquiry. From metallurgy and medicinal chemistry to food preservation and ecological balance, knowledge was developed with a blend of observation, experimentation, and spirituality. Unfortunately, colonial narratives later marginalized this rich heritage, branding it as unscientific.

As a chemistry educator, I often saw my students caught between modern scientific aspirations and a lack of connection to their roots. This tension fuelled my passion to bridge the gap. An opportunity arrived with “**Shaking the Tree**” project, an initiative by the school meant to promote inquiry-based

interdisciplinary learning. As its name suggested, the project aimed to challenge conventional narratives and disturb old habits of learning.

I chose to focus on the theme “**Chemistry in Ancient Bharat**” – a subject close to my heart and one that I believed would make the students proud of their cultural-scientific heritage.

Structuring the journey

The early stages of the project were challenging. The topic initially felt abstract to the students and linking rituals or traditions to science seemed unfamiliar.

There were two key obstacles:

1. **Making ancient knowledge accessible:** Indian chemical knowledge is vast and scattered across sources.
2. **Overcoming stereotypes:** Many students initially viewed ancient practices as superstition, not science.

To address these, we broke the theme into four focused domains and let students select their areas of interest. The groups formed were:

- Medicinal chemistry
- Food preservation
- Metallurgy
- General chemistry in daily life



Photos courtesy: Yuvraj Srivastav



This structure offered a sense of ownership. Students were no longer passive recipients but active researchers, and this autonomy sparked a surge in curiosity and engagement.

The research unfolds

Each group, guided by subject mentors, explored their theme through observations, interviews, and experiments.

Medicinal chemistry

Students explored ancient plant-based remedies across historical periods from the Vedic era to the Buddhist traditions. Using texts like *Rigveda*, *Charak Samhita*, and *Sushruta Samhita*, they mapped how traditional practices combined diagnostics with natural compounds, showcasing remarkable precision and knowledge.

Food preservation

This group looked into traditional methods such as drying, pickling, fermenting, and the use of natural preservatives. They connected these practices to modern concepts of microbial control, osmosis, and food chemistry, demonstrating how culture and chemistry coexist in the kitchen.

Metallurgy

Through the study of texts like *Rasaratna Samuccaya*, and *Rasashala* (which were accessed with help from an archaeologist who was helping us with the project), students learned about ancient extraction techniques, alloy creation, and even the distillation of zinc. The comparison with modern metallurgy helped them appreciate India's advanced understanding of materials science.

General chemistry in life

This group examined the science behind seemingly ritualistic practices – eating from metal utensils, seasonal food habits, and the use of clay, ash, and herbs in daily routines. Students uncovered the chemical logic behind these customs, shifting their perspective from superstition to sustainability.

Bridging the past with the present

The outcome of the project went far beyond what I expected:

- **Scientific literacy with cultural roots:** Students began seeing textbook terms like *oxidation*, *fermentation*, and *distillation* in real life.
- **Historical awareness:** Learners gained an appreciation for India's contribution to global science.





- **Analytical growth:** Comparing ancient and modern practices honed critical thinking.
- **Cultural confidence:** Students proudly shared how their grandparents' practices were rooted in scientific principles.

One group even designed a working model of ancient metallurgical process and food processing, reimagining a traditional technique using modern tools – a proud moment that sparked inspiration among peers and was praised by evaluators.

Challenges and growth

The journey wasn't without hurdles. From managing vast content to keeping student engagement consistent amidst academic demands, we faced many tests. But collaboration with local experts, alignment with the syllabus, and continuous encouragement kept the momentum alive.

A project that became a movement

What began as a classroom initiative evolved into a powerful educational movement. Students now view their heritage as a resource, not a relic. They see their homes and traditions as living laboratories of science.

The culminating event featured group presentations, interactive exhibits, and even the planting of a school herbal garden. Posters, reflection journals, and student portfolios were displayed – each telling a story of discovery, identity, and scientific connection.

Looking forward

As we wrapped up the project, I found myself reflecting on the real learning: that education is not only about learning new things, but also about remembering the ancient wisdom we often overlook. In this fusion of tradition and innovation, my students discovered not only the science of the past, but also their future as thinkers, explorers, and mindful learners. The findings of the project are now being implemented as part of the curriculum up to grade 6.

Yuvraj Srivastav is a Post Graduate Teacher (PGT) of chemistry at JB Academy, Ayodhya. He is passionate about integrating cultural heritage with scientific learning, and actively engages students in experiential, interdisciplinary projects that connect traditional wisdom with modern education. The author can be reached at [<yuvraj930@jbacademy.org>](mailto:yuvraj930@jbacademy.org).

Beyond the *doha*: can music become mainstream curriculum?

Pradita Nambiar

In the typical Indian classroom, Kabir is a prisoner. He is trapped between the stiff pages of the Hindi textbook, reduced to a handful of *dohas* (couplets) to be memorized for an exam. Students learn about his *nirgun* philosophy*, but they rarely *feel* his fire. We ask them to decode his metaphors on paper, but we never ask them to sing his truth.

What if we stopped *teaching* Kabir and started *living* him? What if we replaced the chalkboard with a *dotara* (a musical instrument) and the textbook with a *Baul* song?

This is not a romantic fantasy. It is the reality of the Shabad Shaala project. Over the past year, as part of the larger [Kabir Project](#), we attempted something different in our school: we took the children of classes 6 and 7 and immersed them in the musical traditions of Kabir, not as a co-curricular activity, but as a new kind of mainstream pedagogy.

Here is what we learned about music, knowledge, and the burden we place in our boats.

The corruption of a word: from 'shabd' to 'shabad'

The project's name itself is a political act. The word 'shabd' (Sanskrit for sacred sound) was deliberately corrupted to 'Shabad' – a conscious effort to de-Sanskritize the term, to make it earthy, human, and accessible. Alongside singing, we introduced *Rammat* – a Gujarati word that simply means 'play.' In that linguistic shift lies the entire philosophy of the project. We were not here to perform the usual rituals of learning; we were here to play with ideas.

The goal was to rescue Kabir from the confines of the Hindi classroom and bring him into the open;

*In the **Kabir Project**, the *nirgun* philosophy explores the Divine as formless, attribute-less, and omnipresent. Championed by the 15th-century mystic poet Kabir, it rejects religious rituals, idolatry, and caste divisions, teaching that the ultimate truth resides within each human being.

to use his songs as a vehicle for conversations about environment, ethics, gender, and the very nature of knowledge.

But before we could do that with the children, we had to start with the teachers.

The teacher immersion – unburdening the boat

As the first step in the Shabad Shaala journey, we teachers came together for a three-day immersive workshop. This was not a typical 'training.' There were no learning objectives written on a board. Instead, we sat on the floor and sang.

One session, in particular, had great revelations. Psychologist Sadia Saeed, who worked on the film [Bhavsagar Ke Paar](#), (a short animated parable about the art of sailing across the sea of life with a few Kabir poems as guides!) held space for a single, terrifying question: "What is creating the burden in my boat?"

For a room full of teachers – juggling syllabi, exams, and administration, this was a vulnerable encounter. We realized that before we could teach Kabir's lightness, we had to acknowledge our own heaviness. The immersion wasn't just pedagogic; it was deeply personal.

Why class 6

Why classes 6 and 7? In the Indian system, these grades occupy a golden window. They have left the playfulness of primary school, but are not yet crushed by the board exam pressure of class 10. They are curious, emotionally available, and have not yet learned the adolescent art of hiding their wonder. It is the perfect age to plant the seeds of philosophy before the storms of adolescence arrive.

The Satsang – when the floor is the great equalizer

The heart of Shabad Shaala is the *Mandli* (group) session. In July, we invited the artists. Not on a

stage, but on the floor. Singers like Mukhtiyar Ali, Moorallala Marwada, Kaluram Bamaniya, and Laxman Das Baul sat cross-legged with our children.

This physical reduction of distance was transformative. When a child sits *next* to a bard, the hierarchy dissolves. The artists sang in the local languages of rural communities – languages that carry the raw philosophy of the Sufi saints, unpolished by urban elitism.

The Baul workshop: One of the most magical days was when Laxman Das Baulji arrived. Our children, who are more familiar with Telugu, were suddenly singing in Bengali. They learned to play the *dotara* and the *ananda lahiri*. They danced. They were not just learning about the Baul tradition, they were becoming Bauls for an hour. This was not a music period. It was a cultural integration of language, rhythm, and heritage.

The children prepared for these sessions by writing the lyrics in their notebooks. They came prepared. They sang with interest. And the atmosphere in that room? It was not discipline. It was joy.

Ulat bani – wisdom in the upside-down

One of the most stimulating aspects of the project was our engagement with *ulat bani* (upside-down verse). This is a whole genre of poetry by Kabir and other nirgun poets called *ulatbansi* – upside-down verse that reveals through bafflement, riddling, and absurdity. As the [Ajab Shahar project](#) beautifully puts it, this is where “wisdom hides in laughter at the impossible, where truth hides in paradox.”

During one *mandli* session, the musicians posed riddles to the children: *What does Kabir mean when he says the child is birthing the mother? Or that the branches are below and the roots are above?*

These riddles allowed children to let their imaginations soar. There were no wrong answers. The children generated wonderful, original interpretations that no textbook could have provided.

The drama of truth: Building on this spirit of paradox, we staged a Hindi play. The play was set in a kingdom where no one could speak the truth – not the ministers, not the soldiers, not even the King himself. Each character lived in fear of losing something: power, status, safety.

After the play, we conducted an activity called ‘Sach Kahun Toh’ (If I Speak the Truth). We asked the children to examine their own lives. When do they fail to speak the truth? What are they afraid of losing?

The answers were heartbreakingly honest. Many children spoke of friendship: *“I don’t want to lose my best friend, so I don’t tell them when they have hurt me.”* Others spoke of parental expectations: *“I want to make my parents happy, so I sometimes hide my real feelings.”*

This activity provided a rare space for children to unburden themselves. It brought a sense of emotional wellbeing. They were learning that Kabir’s ‘upside-down’ world is actually the right-side-up one – where truth is rare, and fear is common.

Rammat – the play of knowledge

The singing was the hook. The *Rammat* was the anchor. After each session, we moved from the heart to the head. We discussed the ideologies of the poet through drama, drawing, and dialogue.

Activity 1: Gyani kaun? (Who is knowledgeable?)

I began a session with a simple question: *“What does the word ‘knowledge’ mean?”*

The usual answers came: *“Information.” “Knowing Nature.” “Experience.”*



Photos courtesy: Art For Causes

Then I pushed them: *"If I know how to cook, but I never cook, am I knowledgeable?"*

The class shook their heads. A child clarified, *"You need to cook and also know about cooking."* Theory alone, they argued, will only go so far.

I then asked them to draw a picture of a 'knowledgeable person.' The results were telling. They drew parents, older siblings, Abdul Kalam, Einstein, Gandhi, and Oppenheimer. One brave child drew himself. This was a slanted way of saying: *Why must the 'gyani' always be an adult?*

This led to a hard reflection for us as teachers. Why do our children visualize knowledge only in scientists and Nobel winners? Why not the school gardener? Why not the *ayamma* (helper) who knows how to clean without wasting water? Has Kabir himself been appropriated into this 'achievers list' simply because we sing his songs?

The second day: pushing the argument

Twenty minutes of the earlier session was not enough. I returned the next day and told them: *Knowledge = Knowing. Knowledgeable = Someone who knows AND does.*

Suddenly, the penny dropped. A child gave the example of carpentry. *"It is not enough to know about carpentry,"* he said. *"You should be able to make a table."*

I asked them to rewrite their list. The scientists and pilots stayed. But then, a small voice said: *"Weaver."* Then: *"Potter."* Then: *"Gardener."*

They had moved from the thinker to the person who does manual labour. They had recognized that doing is a form of knowing.

I pushed further. I told them the story of elephants in Wayanad who sensed landslides and saved humans. I asked about the intelligence of dogs, the hard work of bulls.

I listed the 'features' of a typical 'knowledgeable person':

1. Being a man.
2. Wearing spectacles.
3. Being old.
4. Going to foreign universities.
5. Winning Nobel prizes.

I asked the children: *Is this necessary?*

A child jumped in: *"We forgot plants and trees."*

Finally, we had arrived. The children concluded: *Every being is knowledgeable in their own way.* The soil had been loosened. The seeding could begin.

Activity 2: Chala chali ka kela – the game of loss

Another *Rammat* session was called Chala chali ka kela (a playful phrase suggesting a game of coming and going). Here, we examined scenarios of irreversible loss. We asked the children to think of a person, animal, or thing they were deeply attached to but had lost forever – someone or something they would never meet again.

The responses were tender. One child spoke of their favourite toy, given away by parents because *"I have grown older now."* Another remembered an auto-rickshaw driver who used to bring them to school every day. *"I don't get to meet him anymore. I don't even know if he remembers me."*

This was not morbid. It was cathartic. In a culture that often tells children to 'move on' or 'not cry over small things,' *Chala chali ka kela* gave them permission to name their grief. They learned that Kabir's poetry is not abstract philosophy – it is a space for the real ache of loss that every human feels.

Sab jag jalta dekhyā – the fires within

The next *Rammat* we attempted was on the theme *Sab jag jalta dekhyā* (I saw the whole world burning). We showed a presentation on Greta Thunberg, interspersed with slides on climate change, wars, and communal tensions. The thesis was simple: the fires outside (wars, pollution) are manifestations of the fires inside (greed, jealousy, pride).





The task was a 7-minute skit, which the children had to prepare in 15-20 minutes.

Group 1 chose the Russia-Ukraine war. I loved that they had Putin say he wanted to be a “macho man.” They understood ego as a driver of history. (Though they struggled to find a solution – don’t we all?).

Group 2 staged a school drama about craving a new bag or pencil pouch. It was delightfully childlike. They resolved the conflict themselves, without a teacher. I felt the resolution came too soon, but perhaps that is how children heal – they simply decide to move forward.

Group 3 imagined two kings debating technology and Nature. I left them with a question: *Why did you think of kings? We don’t have kings anymore.* They realized that democratically elected leaders often behave like kings. In their skit, the kings listened to the common people. The citizens were divided, but finally the kings chose a balanced path.

The unseen healing – a confession

I cannot end this article without speaking personally. I joined the Shabad Shaala project soon after a personal tragedy. My body was tired and my spirit was broken. I was showing up to school mechanically, doing my duty, but feeling hollow.

Engaging with this project – singing Kabir, sitting in *Rammat* with the children, listening to their absurd riddles and their honest confessions about friendship and loss – became my own quiet therapy. The project did not ask me to be a perfect teacher. It asked me to be a fellow seeker.

The songs and the *Rammat* activities took root deep within me. They worked in invisible ways – healing

not through advice or counselling, but through rhythm, paradox, and shared vulnerability. By the time we reached *Chala chali ka kela*, I found myself grieving my own losses alongside the children. And somehow that made the load lighter.

If a curriculum can heal a teacher, imagine what it can do for a child.

Can music become mainstream?

So, can music become part of the mainstream curriculum in India?

Not if we treat it as a break from ‘real work.’ But if we use music as a *method* – to bring marginalized voices (like the Bauls or Kabir) into the center, and to examine concepts like knowledge, loss, and truth – then it is not just possible; it is necessary.

The Shabad Shaala project taught us five things:

1. **Music creates safety.** When a child sings, they are ready to discuss complex topics like war, greed, and grief without anxiety.
2. **The artist is the best teacher.** We cannot teach Kabir without the minstrels. The curriculum must allow for *sangat* (community) with living traditions, not just dead texts.
3. **Paradox and riddles work.** *Ulat bani* teaches children that we need not fear confusion, it is the doorway to wisdom.
4. **Rammat (play) is serious.** Drama, drawing, and games like *Chala chali ka kela* allow children to arrive at ‘Gyani kaun’ or ‘Sach kahun toh’ faster than any talk ever could.
5. **The teacher heals too.** A curriculum that is alive will not leave the teacher untouched. Our own wellbeing matters in this work.

We still have a long way to go. But for now, in the soil of class 6, we have planted something rare. We have told our children that the gardener is a *gyani*. We have told them that a child can be knowledgeable. We have let them grieve their lost auto-rickshaw uncles and toys that were given away. And we have told them that before you solve the fires of the world, you must look at the fire within your own selves.

That is not just music education. That is liberation.

Pradita Nambiar is a teacher at Vidyaranya School, Hyderabad. She is involved in the Shabad Shaala project under the Kabir Project. The author can be reached at <pradita_n@yahoo.com>.

Making connections: real-world mathematics

Monica Kochar

Eleven-year-old Ravi from my grade 5 classroom arrived at school one morning with an urgent mathematical problem. His father, a rickshaw driver, had asked him to figure out the most profitable route during the upcoming festival season. "Should I take more short rides within the city or fewer long rides to the outskirts?" his father had wondered aloud.

What started as a family conversation became the most engaging mathematics lesson our grade 5 had ever experienced. We spent weeks exploring distance calculations, rate comparisons, fuel costs, time analysis, and profit optimization, all because Ravi's father needed real mathematical thinking to support his family's livelihood.

This experience taught me something profound: when mathematics connects with students' real worlds, it transforms from an abstract school subject into a powerful thinking tool that has immediate meaning and purpose.

The power of mathematical context

Real-world connections aren't just nice additions to mathematics lessons, they're fundamental to how humans learn mathematical concepts. When six-year-old Priya in grade 1 learns addition by figuring out how many more bangles she needs to match her mother's collection, she's not just learning $3 + 5 = 8$. She's understanding addition as a tool for solving problems that matter to her.

Research consistently shows that students learn mathematical concepts more deeply and retain them longer when those concepts are embedded in meaningful contexts (Brown, Collins, & Duguid, 1989). But in Indian classrooms, we often face the challenge of connecting curriculum content to the diverse life experiences of our students.

The key is recognizing that every student comes to school with a rich mathematical background from their daily lives. Our job is to honour that background while expanding their mathematical thinking through carefully chosen real-world connections.

Early years: mathematics in daily life (LKG – grade 2)

Young children naturally see mathematics in their world, but they just don't always recognize it as "mathematics." Four-year-old Meera knows exactly how to share two *gulab jamuns* equally between herself and her sister. She understands division; she just doesn't know the formal term yet.

In early childhood, real-world connections focus on making visible the mathematics that already exists in children's experiences.

Kitchen mathematics: Cooking and eating provide endless opportunities for counting, measuring, fractions, and time. "How many rotis do we need for our family?" becomes a lesson in multiplication.

Festival mathematics: Diwali preparations involve geometric patterns in rangoli, counting diyas, calculating sweets needed for guests, and understanding symmetry in decorations.

Market mathematics: Shopping trips reveal addition, subtraction, money concepts, and estimation. "Will Rs.50 be enough for vegetables?" becomes authentic problem-solving.

Home mathematics: Organizing toys teaches sorting and classification. Setting the table involves one-to-one correspondence. Sharing snacks introduces fair division.

The goal isn't to formalize these experiences, but to help children see that mathematical thinking is everywhere in their daily lives.

Primary years: expanding mathematical horizons (grades 3-5)

By grade 3, students are ready for more intentional connections between school mathematics and real-world applications. This is when we can begin using their life experiences as launching points for mathematical investigations.

Nine-year-old Anjali lived in a housing complex where water was supplied for only two hours each morning. Her question – "Why doesn't everyone get enough water?" – led to a mathematical exploration involving:

- **Data collection:** Surveying families about water usage.
- **Graphing:** Representing water supply patterns visually.
- **Calculations:** Computing water needs versus water availability.
- **Problem-solving:** Designing more efficient water distribution systems.

Through this investigation, grade 4 students learned statistical concepts, graphing skills, and multiplicative reasoning not because these were in the curriculum, but because they needed these mathematical tools to understand a real problem affecting their lives.

Sports mathematics: Cricket statistics become data analysis lessons. Football formations introduce geometry and strategic thinking.

Transportation mathematics: Local bus routes teach distance, time, and rate calculations. Train schedules introduce time intervals and scheduling problems.

Community mathematics: School enrollment numbers, election results, and population growth become contexts for large number operations and graphing.



A student demonstrating the results of a survey she conducted through a graph

Middle school: mathematical modeling of complex systems (grades 6-8)

Middle school students can handle more sophisticated real-world applications that require abstract thinking and mathematical modeling. Twelve-year-old Kiran noticed that traffic jams were getting worse in his neighborhood and asked, "How many more cars can our roads handle?"

This question opened up explorations in:

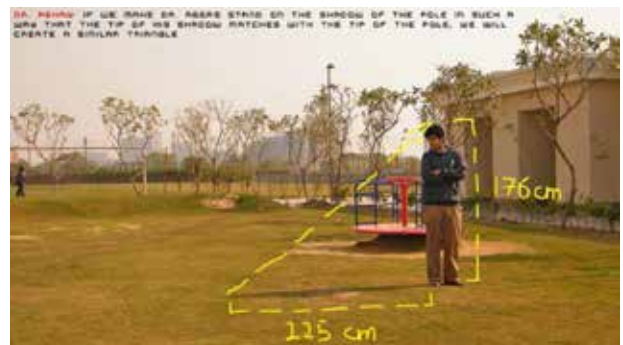
- **Algebra:** Creating equations to model traffic flow.
- **Statistics:** Analyzing traffic patterns over time.
- **Geometry:** Calculating road capacity and optimal intersection design.
- **Problem-solving:** Proposing solutions based on mathematical evidence.

Environmental mathematics: Climate data becomes graphing and trend analysis. Pollution levels introduce scientific notation and exponential functions.

Economic mathematics: Local business profits and losses teach integers. Currency exchange rates for students with relatives abroad introduce proportion and percent.

Social mathematics: Population growth, resource distribution, and social media usage patterns become contexts for exploring exponential functions, data analysis, and modeling.

Technology mathematics: How GPS works, how search engines rank results, and how recommendation algorithms function, all provide authentic contexts for mathematical exploration.



A student using proportions to find the height of the school building

High school: mathematics for career and citizenship (grades 9-12)

By grade 9, real-world connections should help students see mathematics as essential for their future

careers and informed citizenship. Fifteen-year-old Kavya, who wanted to become a fashion designer asked, "How is mathematics used in fashion?"

This led to investigations involving:

- **Geometry:** Pattern design and fabric optimization.
- **Ratios and proportions:** Scaling designs and calculating material needs.
- **Trigonometry:** Understanding how fabric drapes and falls.
- **Statistics:** Analyzing fashion trends and consumer preferences.

Healthcare mathematics: Dosage calculations, epidemic modeling, and medical imaging provide contexts for proportional reasoning, exponential functions, and coordinate geometry.

Engineering mathematics: Bridge design, building construction, and mechanical systems offer authentic applications for trigonometry, physics, and calculus concepts.

Business mathematics: Profit analysis, loan calculations, investment growth, and market analysis provide meaningful contexts for algebraic thinking and financial literacy.

Agricultural mathematics: Crop yields, irrigation patterns, weather modeling, and soil analysis connect mathematics to one of India's most important economic sectors.



Students using a clinometer to find the height of the school building

Cultural mathematics: honouring mathematical heritage

India has an incredibly rich mathematical heritage that provides authentic contexts for learning across

all grade levels. Ancient Indian mathematicians made fundamental contributions to mathematics that students can explore and appreciate.

Vedic mathematics: Traditional calculation methods that show alternative approaches to arithmetic and algebraic operations.

Architectural mathematics: The mathematical principles behind ancient Indian temples, forts, and palaces provide contexts for geometry and proportion.

Musical mathematics: The mathematical relationships in Indian classical music, including ragas, talas, and harmonic structures.

Astronomical mathematics: Ancient Indian astronomical calculations and calendar systems introduce concepts of cycles, large numbers, and geometric thinking.

Artistic mathematics: Mathematical patterns in Indian textiles, pottery, and visual arts provide contexts for symmetry, tessellations, and geometric design.

Multilingual mathematical contexts

In our diverse Indian classrooms, students bring mathematical concepts from different linguistic and cultural backgrounds. Instead of seeing this as a challenge, I've learned to use it as a resource.

When teaching fractions in grade 4, students shared how different communities describe parts of wholes:

- Tamil students talked about "**பாகம்**" (bagam – parts)
- Hindi speakers shared "**भाग**" (bhag – division)
- English learners connected to "fraction" and "piece"

These multilingual connections helped all students develop a deeper understanding of fractional concepts while honouring their cultural knowledge.

Technology as mathematical context

Modern students live in a digital world that provides countless opportunities for mathematical connections. Instead of treating technology as separate from mathematics, I integrate it naturally.

Smartphone mathematics: Data usage patterns, battery life optimization, and storage calculations provide contexts for mathematical modeling.

Quick resources you can use

For early childhood teachers (LKG – grade 2)

- **Daily life mathematics:** Point out counting, measuring, and comparing in cooking, shopping, and household activities.
- **Festival mathematics:** Use celebrations to explore patterns, counting, and geometric shapes in decorations.
- **Nature mathematics:** Find mathematical patterns in flowers, leaves, and animals.

For primary teachers (grades 3-5)

- **Community problem solving:** Use local issues (water supply, traffic, waste management) as mathematical investigation contexts.
- **Sports and games:** Connect mathematical concepts to popular games and sports statistics.
- **Family business mathematics:** Explore how families use mathematics in their work and daily decision-making.

For middle school teachers (grades 6-8)

- **Current events mathematics:** Use news stories as contexts for data analysis, graphing, and mathematical modeling.
- **Social media mathematics:** Analyze follower growth, engagement rates, and viral spread patterns.
- **Environmental mathematics:** Study local environmental data through mathematical lenses.

For high school teachers (grades 9-12)

- **Career connections:** Show how mathematical concepts apply to various career paths students are considering.
- **Economic mathematics:** Use local business data, economic indicators, and financial planning as mathematical contexts.
- **Technology mathematics:** Explore how mathematics underlies GPS, search engines, and digital communication.

Gaming mathematics: Probability in games, scoring systems, and strategic optimization connect to mathematical thinking students use during leisure time.

Social media mathematics: Follower growth patterns, engagement rates, and viral spread introduce exponential functions and statistical analysis.

Internet mathematics: How search algorithms work, how encryption keeps information safe, and how compression reduces file sizes – all provide authentic contexts for advanced mathematical concepts.

Assessment through real-world applications

Traditional mathematics assessment often disconnects learning from application. I've developed assessment strategies that maintain real-world connections:

Project-based assessment: Students solve actual problems from their communities using mathematical tools and present solutions to real audiences.

Mathematical portfolios: Collections of real-world problems students have solved, showing growth in mathematical modeling and application skills.

Community presentations: Students present mathematical findings to parents, local officials, or community groups, demonstrating authentic communication of mathematical ideas.

Peer problem creation: Students create real-world mathematical problems for classmates to solve, requiring a deep understanding of both mathematical concepts and authentic contexts.

Overcoming implementation challenges

Creating authentic real-world connections isn't always easy in structured educational systems. Common challenges include:

Curriculum pressure: When we feel pressured to "cover" specific topics, it's tempting to skip real-world connections. But I've learned that students understand concepts more quickly and deeply when they're connected to meaningful contexts.

Resource limitations: Real-world connections don't require expensive materials – they require creative thinking and willingness to foreground students' experiences to find their connection with mathematical concepts.

Assessment alignment: When assessments focus on isolated skills rather than mathematical application, it can seem like real-world connections are "extra." But students who learn mathematics in context perform better on traditional assessments too.

The long-term impact

Students who experience mathematics through real-world connections develop different relationships with mathematical thinking. They see mathematics as a tool for understanding and improving their world, not just as a school subject to endure.

Ravi, whose father's rickshaw problem began this article, is now in grade 8 and regularly helps his father analyze business decisions using mathematical thinking. More importantly, he sees himself as someone who uses mathematics to solve real problems – an identity that will serve him throughout his life.

When mathematics connects to students' real worlds, it transforms from abstract symbols on paper to powerful thinking tools that help them understand, analyze, and improve the world around them.

Remember: The best real-world connections come from listening to your students' lives and interests, then finding authentic ways to connect those experiences to mathematical thinking.

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Monica Kochar is a seasoned educator and curriculum designer specializing in math education. With over 10 years of experience, she created HumaneMath, a human-centric math programme, and has worked with leading organizations in edtech, publishing, and training. Her expertise spans curriculum design, teacher training, assessments, and quality review. Monica has contributed to key startups, including WhiteHat Jr., and mentored several initiatives. She holds a Master's in Education from the University of the People. The author can be reached at <humanemath@gmail.com>.

Teaching

Teaching geopolitics in Indian schools does not mean turning the classroom into a place for political arguments. It means helping students understand how geography, history, trade, migration, resources, and communication already shape the India they live in, and the wider world too.

Indian students already come across global and national issues all the time through TV news, YouTube Shorts, WhatsApp forwards, reels, and family discussions about issues like India-China border tensions, the Russia-Ukraine war, or oil prices in West Asia. If teachers avoid these topics, the issues don't disappear. Students still form opinions, but they do so based on incomplete or unchecked information, without any adult guiding them to think clearly.

The real challenge for Indian teachers isn't whether to teach geopolitics, but how to teach it fairly in a diverse democracy. Students these days see breaking news and strong opinions faster than any previous generation, often through short clips with no context, long before a textbook explains the background. A conflict anywhere in the world can reach a student's phone within minutes, often as a meme or a dramatic headline. By the time it reaches a classroom, many students already have strong feelings based on partial facts. So, geopolitics isn't just a topic for older students; even middle schoolers have opinions about world events, mostly shaped by what they hear outside school.

This is exactly why it's worth teaching well. Parents and school administrators watch closely for bias, and even one lesson that feels one-sided can lead to complaints, no matter what the teacher intended. Students arrive with views formed by their home, region, social media, and friends. A teacher's job isn't to erase these views, but to help students question them thoughtfully. Understanding different points of view is also becoming a real workplace skill. Indian employers in IT, consulting, and multinational companies value people who can handle uncertainty, work with international clients, and think beyond a single story.

The best classroom approach is to stop asking "who was right" and instead ask "what did each side want, and how did they justify their actions?" This works whether the topic is the India-Pakistan Indus Waters Treaty or India's role in the Non-Aligned Movement. This keeps lessons honest, because most geopolitical conflicts, from river-sharing disputes between

students to think globally

Neerja Singh

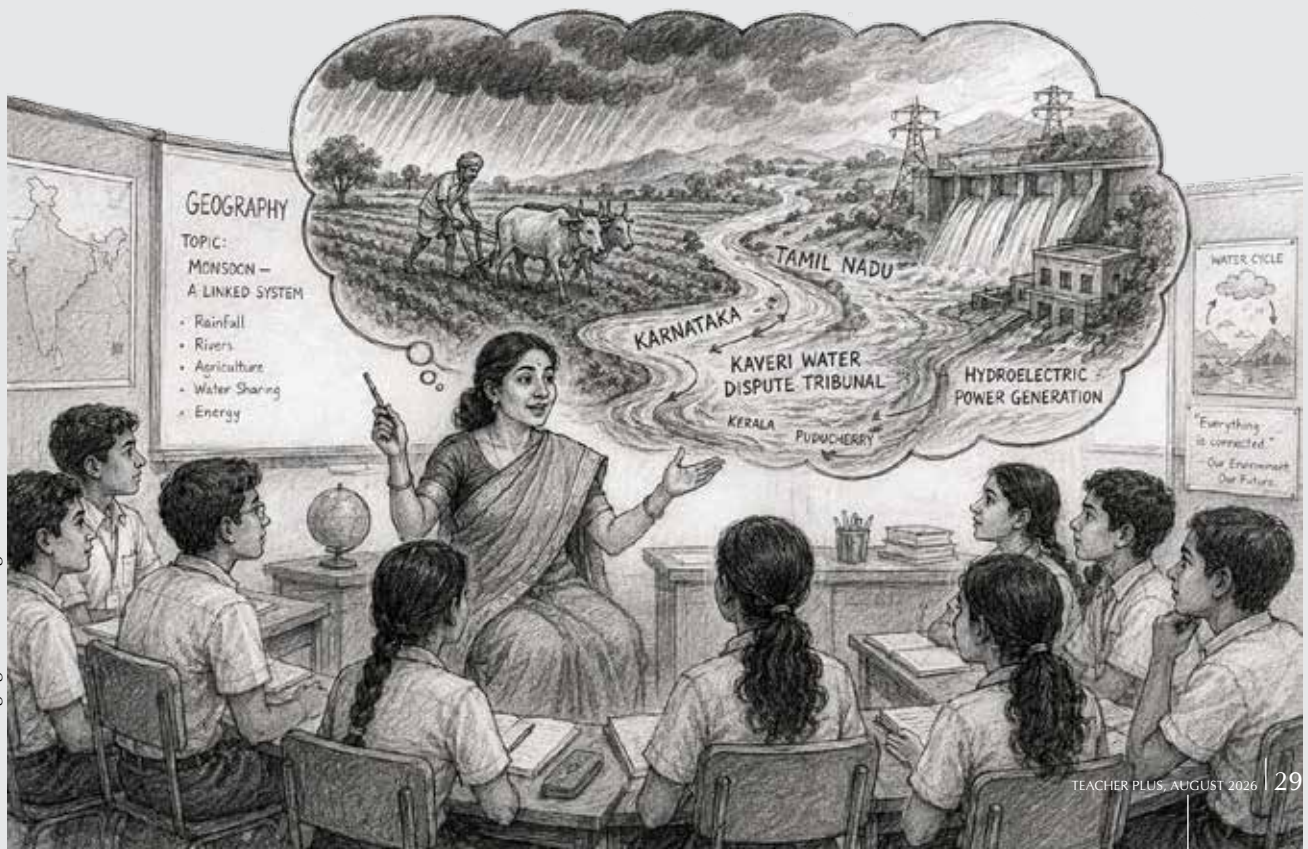
states to cross-border tensions, involve several valid claims, not a simple story of good versus bad. It also protects teachers from being accused of pushing an agenda, since the focus is on evidence and motives, not picking a winner.

This "multiple perspectives" method, long used in history classes, works well for Indian geopolitics too. Students can read official statements or credible summaries from different sides of an issue, say, Indian and Pakistani positions on the Indus Waters Treaty, or different states' arguments before river water tribunals, and map out what each side feared, wanted, and gave up. Instead of picking a winner, students identify what each side was afraid of losing, what evidence they used, and how geography and history shaped their choices. Once students practice this on older, settled issues, they can apply the same thinking more safely to current events.

India's river disputes are great, well-documented examples for classrooms. The Krishna Water Disputes

Tribunal, which divided river water between Maharashtra, Karnataka, and Andhra Pradesh/Telangana, shows how scarcity and development goals create tension – but also how formal systems can resolve it. The Kaveri dispute between Karnataka and Tamil Nadu, and the Narmada issue involving Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, and Maharashtra, show how states with different rainfall and farming needs negotiate sharing a river. The Indus Waters Treaty between India and Pakistan shows how two countries with a history of conflict still managed to cooperate for decades through detailed rules and shared data.

These examples let students work with real tribunal decisions, maps, and irrigation data, building analytical skills without the emotional weight of a breaking news story. In class, students can study which river basins are under stress, how climate change affects water flow, and why people upstream and downstream see the same river so differently. Teachers can ask how decisions about dams and canals affect farmers, fisherfolk, city residents, and the environment differently across states.



Migration is another topic students already see around them. Families move from Bihar or Uttar Pradesh to Punjab, Delhi, or Maharashtra for work; from rural Odisha or Jharkhand to construction sites in Bengaluru or Hyderabad; and from smaller towns to big cities for school and jobs. Many students also have relatives in Canada, the Gulf, Australia, or the US. Instead of treating migration as a political issue, teachers can ask what pushes people to leave...like rural poverty or lack of jobs and what pulls them elsewhere, like better wages or opportunities in IT, healthcare, or hospitality. Students can also look at how new arrivals settle in through language support, peer mentoring, and activities that respect different festivals and foods. This builds both empathy and analytical skill, connected to real experiences rather than abstract ideas.

Programmes like Model United Nations, already common in India through school clubs and platforms like IPMUN and India MUN, are a proven way to teach geopolitics fairly. Students represent countries or committees whose views may differ sharply from their own, and argue those positions using real diplomatic language. A student from Mohali might represent Brazil on climate finance; a student from Hyderabad might argue China's position on trade. For the length of the event, they must research their assigned country's real policies and respond to others like an actual diplomat. This builds a deeper, more balanced understanding of world affairs, and teachers often notice students becoming more careful about jumping to conclusions and more focused on evidence.

None of this needs a separate "geopolitics" class; it fits naturally into subjects India already teaches. In geography, monsoons, farming, and natural resources link to water-sharing and energy issues, and lessons on ports and trade routes can explain why shipping lanes through places like the Strait of Malacca affect everyday prices. In history, units on colonialism and partition connect to how India's borders and global alliances evolved, including its role in the Non-Aligned Movement during the Cold War. In civics, chapters on the Constitution and federalism connect to river-water disputes and India's role in the UN, G20, and BRICS. In economics, trade policy and global supply chains are linked to real business case studies, like shifts in trade patterns and data rules. In environmental science, students can study India's climate commitments and how climate change affects different regions differently. Even a simple lesson on food can trace where India's wheat, rice, or edible oil imports come from, and how global disruptions ripple through Indian markets and prices.

A few simple techniques help keep discussions constructive across all these subjects. One is showing

two credible sources with different views of the same event, say, two editorials on a border incident, or two news reports on the Kaveri dispute from different states and asking students to spot where they agree and where they differ. Structured formats like [Socratic seminars](#) or [fishbowl discussions](#) keep conversations evidence-based and orderly, making sure every student takes part without the session turning into a shouting match. A "steel man" exercise asking students to explain an opposing view as fairly and persuasively as its supporters would, before criticizing it, builds real understanding before disagreement. A simple two-column chart separating verified facts, like treaty dates or rainfall data, from differing interpretations, like claims about fairness or threat, helps students see that most disagreement lies in interpretation, not in the facts themselves. And giving students a few quiet minutes to write down their thoughts before discussing sensitive topics helps them process emotions calmly, without feeling the pressure to perform a certain stance in front of classmates.

Even with careful planning, teachers may face pushback from worried parents or administrators, especially in politically tense times. The answer isn't to avoid geopolitics but to be transparent, sharing lesson goals and source materials in advance, explaining that the aim is skill-building rather than pushing an agenda, and using varied sources like NCERT texts and newspapers in different languages. Schools that openly explain how they choose case studies, favouring well-documented treaties over live partisan controversies, tend to build trust with families more quickly.

In the end, teaching geopolitics without bias isn't about pretending every view is equally correct or manufacturing false neutrality. It's about giving students the tools to understand why thoughtful people from different states, communities, and countries can look at the same facts and reach different conclusions. When a classroom helps students separate evidence from interpretation, recognize competing interests, and take seriously views they don't personally hold, it prepares them for a world and workplace where ambiguity is normal, and quick, reactive answers rarely tell the whole story.

Neerja Singh is a generational bridge, speaker, author of six generational books, and an ICF credentialed generational coach. A TEDx speaker and certified virtual presenter, she assists multinational companies, educational institutions, and the armed forces in bridging generational gaps. An Oxford University Press Resource Person, she is an alumna of the Indian Institute of Management, Trichy. The author can be reached at <https://www.linkedin.com/in/neerja-singh/>.

How well do you know your food?

Sujata C

This worksheet is suitable
for classes 5 to 7.

Food is the spice of life. The variety of flavours, spices, and ingredients in Indian food whets the appetite and makes life exciting. In India, there are as many regional cuisines as the number of states. Exploring the different cuisines is a great way to inject some spice into our lives. This worksheet will help increase awareness about food besides developing the objective and analytical thinking abilities of the students.

1. Map your foods

Write the name of the state to which the following food items belong.

- | | | | |
|---------------|-------------------|-----------------|--------------------|
| 1. Dhokla | 6. Idli/dosa | 11. Macher jhol | 16. Aapam |
| 2. Dhansak | 7. Kulcha | 12. Jhalmuri | 17. Chicken xacuti |
| 3. Pulihora | 8. Sarson da saag | 13. Luchi | 18. Ambal |
| 4. Puran poli | 9. Naan | 14. Poha | 19. Kosambari |
| 5. Jalebi | 10. Dal bati | 15. Upma | 20. Panjiri |

Same dal, different taste: You have tasted dal fry and sambar. Did you know that both are made with the same dal – tuar or arhar? What is it called in your mother tongue? Find out the many ways the commonly consumed tuar dal is cooked in different states.

2. Know your spices and herbs

- Prepare a chart of the following herbs and spices.
- Answer these questions: Define herb and spice. Are ginger and garlic herbs or spices?

- | | | |
|-----------------|--------------------|-------------|
| 1. Curry leaves | 6. Black pepper | 11. Nutmeg |
| 2. Mint | 7. Cinnamon | 12. Mace |
| 3. Coriander | 8. Clove | 13. Chilli |
| 4. Kasuri methi | 9. Cardamom | 14. Cumin |
| 5. Oregano | 10. Black cardamom | 15. Mustard |

3. Indian food goes global

Today, the world is discovering that Indian cuisine is much more than butter chicken and paneer! Many Indian origin citizens are now giving a taste of regional and authentic Indian foods to the locals of foreign countries. Even millets have made their way to the menu in many foreign countries.

- Millets: Name five millets and at least one dish made with a millet.
- Regional cuisines: How many regional cuisines are you familiar with?
- Traditional pickles: Participate in a pickle making activity at home.
- Fermented foods: How many fermented foods do you know?
- Local vegetables: Visit a local vegetable market. Make a list of all the vegetables and fruits you see there. Ask the vendors whether these are available locally or procured from outside. Make a note.

Activity

Talk to your parents and grandparents or other elders in the family and find out about the traditional foods commonly made at home. Write about two or three traditional foods from your region.

1. _____
2. _____

Every day we make choices about what we eat. Some foods nourish our bodies, while others are fun foods that provide little nutrition. Let's become food detectives and learn more about the foods we eat.

4. Empty calories, emotional eating, and hidden hunger

What are empty calories?

Some foods provide energy through added sugars but have no or very few essential nutrients like vitamins, minerals, protein, or fibre. These foods fill the stomach but do not nourish the body.

Examples:

- Soft drinks
- Sugary desserts
- Candies
- Ice creams
- Chips

Soft drinks contain too much sugar. Chips have too much salt. Kulfi is better than ice cream nutritionally speaking, as it contains milk that has been thickened by slow-cooking. Ice cream is 50% whipped air.

Make a chart on empty calories and foods that provide empty calories.

Emotional eating

Sometimes people eat not because they are hungry but because they are:

- Sad
- Stressed
- Bored
- Angry
- Lonely

This is called emotional eating.

Activity: Think and reflect

Have you ever eaten something because you were bored?

☐ Yes

☐ No

What did you eat?

Hidden hunger

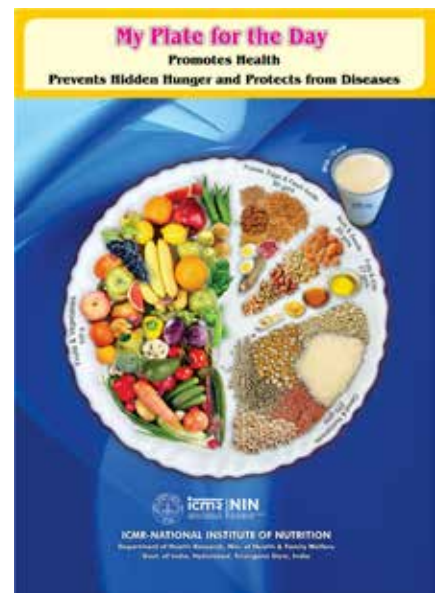
You may eat enough food but still lack important vitamins and minerals. This leads to what is called as hidden hunger.

It can lead to:

- Weakness
- Poor concentration
- Frequent illness
- Poor growth

Eat right

Here is the ICMR-National Institute of Nutrition recommendation for food that should be consumed in a day. When the food on your plate resembles the one in the given picture, you can prevent hidden hunger. Prepare a chart of My Plate for the Day and display it in your class.



Activity

Write three foods rich in:

Iron: _____

Vitamin A: _____

Calcium: _____

Protein: _____

Fats: _____

Starch: _____

Water: _____

5. Know your food label

Food labels tell us:

- Ingredients
- Manufacturing date
- Use by date/Expiry date
- Nutrition information
- FSSAI Licence Number
- Veg (green dot) and Non-veg marking (red dot)

Activity: Label detective

Take any packaged food at home and answer:

1. Product name: _____

2. Ingredients: _____

3. Net weight: _____

4. Max. retail price: _____

5. Fortified food logo: _____

6. Directions for use: _____

7. Manufactured by: _____

8. Marketed by: _____

9. FSSAI license no: _____

10. Manufacturing date: _____

11. Use by date/Expiry date: _____

12. Nutrition information/facts: _____

13. Our product range: _____

- Are there ingredients on the pack that you have not heard of?
- How many languages have been used to share the information on the pack? Why?

Discuss:

- Why should food labels clearly mention ingredients?

6. Know FSSAI



The Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) is an autonomous institution under the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare, Government of India, which ensures that food sold in India is safe. Learning about food helps us stay healthy, avoid food mishaps, and make better decisions for ourselves and our families.

Did you know?

FSSAI advises against wrapping food in newspapers because the printing ink may contain harmful chemicals that can contaminate food. Food inspectors regularly conduct raids at restaurants, meat shops, and dairies to check for adulteration.

- Milk adulteration: Diluting with water and adding chemicals.
- Paneer adulteration: Prepare a report on how paneer is adulterated.
- Recently, FSSAI sent notices to 14 leading brands for unsubstantiated claims. Find out the names of these companies and the claims they made.

Activity

Observe an eatery near your home.

Tick what you see:

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Food covered properly | ☐ Clean surroundings |
| ☐ Vendor wearing gloves | ☐ Hand washing facility |
| ☐ Dustbins available | |

7. Food exports and quality standards

Countries often inspect imported foods to ensure they meet safety standards.

Examples and activities:

- Indian mango exports have occasionally faced restrictions due to pest-control concerns. Which countries banned Indian mangoes due to this reason? Write a brief report on the topic.
- Indian spice brands have faced scrutiny in some countries over quality and safety testing. Why did this happen? Who banned the masalas? Find out and discuss.

What can we learn?

Quality control is important for:

- | | |
|-------------|------------------|
| • Farmers | • Food companies |
| • Consumers | • Exporters |

Activity

Imagine you are a food inspector.

List three checks you would perform:

1. _____
2. _____
3. _____

8. Refined, unrefined, organic, and vegan

Refined foods are processed foods from which parts of the natural food are removed.

Examples:

- White sugar – made by refining sugarcane juice.
- Maida – made by refining wheat flour.
- Polished rice – healthy brown coat of the grain is removed.

Unrefined foods

Remain closer to their natural state. Examples:

- Whole grains
- Jaggery
- Brown rice
- Oils

- Sample two varieties of oils – refined sunflower oil and filtered groundnut oil.
- Do a smell and taste test. Note down your observations.

Organic foods: Produced with minimal use of synthetic pesticides and fertilizers.

- Find out what food qualifies as organic.
- Which organization certifies food as organic?
- What conditions must a farmer fulfill in order to give his produce the organic label?
- Write a report.

Vegan foods: Foods that contain no animal products including milk and milk products.

- Find out when this trend started and why?
- Compare and contrast the food concept of vegans and Jains.
- Visit a vegan market. Talk to the vendors there about the trend. Is veganism slowing down? If yes, why?
- Will a vegan person eat lab grown meat?

9. Food adulteration

Food adulteration means mixing inferior or harmful substances into food. Common examples:

S.No	Food	Possible Adulterants
1	Milk	Water, Starch
2	Honey	Sugar syrup
3	Turmeric	Artificial colour
4	Black pepper	Dried papaya seeds
5	Chilli powder	Brick powder
6	Coriander powder	Saw dust

Activity: Do some simple home tests to check for adulteration.

Milk

Place a drop on a smooth surface. Pure milk leaves a white trail.

Honey

Put a drop in water. Pure honey settles slowly.

Activity

Ask your family about any episode of food adulteration that they have encountered.

Write about it. _____

10. Food poisoning can be deadly

Food poisoning may occur due to:

- Contaminated water
- Poor storage
- Improper cooking
- Bacterial growth

News reports occasionally highlight illnesses and deaths linked to contaminated foods, including cooked rice dishes, cut fruits, and improperly stored foods. Read about the biryani and water melon meal that was fatal and the mangoes that killed two sisters.

Food safety rules

- ✓ Wash hands before cooking/eating: Wet your hands, scrub for 20 seconds, rinse well, and dry with a clean towel.
- ✓ Drink safe water.
- ✓ Avoid stale foods.
- ✓ Check expiry dates.
- ✓ Cover cooked food.

What methods are needed to keep the following food items safe? – Cooking/Cooling

- | | |
|----------------|-------------------|
| a. Milk | d. Curd |
| b. Raw meat | e. Cut fruit |
| c. Eggs | f. Cut vegetables |
| g. Cooked food | |

Hygiene Index: Hyderabad ranks the lowest in food safety and hygiene ratings according to FSSAI.

- Find out why?
- Find out the hygiene ranking of major cities of India.

11. Food in the news

- i. **Energy drinks:** FSSAI has recently cracked down on 'energy drinks'. These 'energy drinks' contain high amounts of synthetic caffeine and sugar that increase the cortisol (stress hormones) levels in the body. There is an appeal for a ban on the sale of energy drinks within a 500-meter radius of schools in Karnataka. Should there be a call for a similar ban in all the states? Read more about this issue and prepare an infographic.
- ii. **Maggi Noodles controversy:** About 10 years ago, Maggi instant noodles became a national topic of discussion due to the discovery of insects and larvae in the packets. This raised concerns regarding food safety standards and labelling and highlighted the importance of food testing and regulation. Recently, the same issue made news once more.

Activity: Read up archives of the news and write a report on the issue.

iii. What is Monosodium Glutamate (MSG)?

MSG is a flavour enhancer used in many foods. It is harmful for young children. Find out how MSG harms the body.

- **Debate:** Divide the class into two groups: For and Against "Instant foods are convenient but not always healthy."
- **Read** news reports on plastic rice and fake flour and discuss in class.

12. Food safety pledge

Prepare a chart with the food safety pledge and display it on the school notice board and in every classroom.

I pledge that I will:

- ☐ Wash my hands before eating.
- ☐ Read food labels.
- ☐ Avoid excessive junk food.
- ☐ Eat more fruits and vegetables.
- ☐ Watch out for unsafe food practices.

13. Food diary

Activity: For one week, maintain a food diary.

S. No	Day	Home-made food	Packaged food	Fruits/vegetables	Water Intake
1	Monday				
2	Tuesday				
3	Wednesday				
4	Thursday				
5	Friday				
6	Saturday				
7	Sunday				

14. Final reflection

What is the one food habit that you would like to change after completing this worksheet?

Remember

The best food is not always the most colourful, expensive, or heavily advertised. The healthiest food is often the simplest, freshest, and closest to Nature.

Sujata C is an independent writer, editor and lifelong learner. The author can be reached at <sujata117@gmail.com>.

Environmental education as a meeting point of pedagogies

Sunanda Ramasamy

Twenty or more butterflies in shades of yellow, black, and orange swirl around the *Ixora* and marigold plants in a park beside a wetland. Accompanying them are the enthusiastic questions and voices of children on a nature walk.

"Why are people fishing there? We should let the fish just be!"

"I know that plant! It's used for making soap!"

"What's the name of that butterfly? What does it eat?"

"What's your name, akka? What do you do?"

"Why is that bird sitting there like that?"

Rapid, scattered questioning can be perceived as disruptive in a typical educational session, but give it some thought and you realize it can be an opportunity for educators to look at how children learn about the world around them.

In India, environmental education was made an academic requirement in 2004 and has since been incorporated at all levels of formal schooling. However, its pedagogy has commonly faced criticism for being relegated to textbook learning. The pressure to excel in "core" subjects like mathematics and science often diminishes the importance of environmental studies, which is treated as optional content for students.

Photos courtesy:
Sunanda Ramasamy

Currently, in mainstream institutions, nature education events are limited to being typically organized by non-profits, with a few sessions held over a school year or as singular events like field trips. In schools with alternative pedagogies, it may be designed into the school's own unique schedule, such as time allocated for silent reflection outdoors. Sometimes, simultaneously balancing the expectations and capacities of different education systems can be tricky for environment educators both in schools and non-profits. The idea of what matters in a child's learning and the resources a school has access to can differ between various pedagogies.

The walkⁱ held for children on a wetland, mentioned at the beginning of this article, is an example of how non-profits may need to negotiate between alternative and mainstream pedagogies. What was originally proposed as a nature journaling session for 20 students eventually became a nature journaling competition for around 100 children from different institutions. Ten batches of 10 students were led along the wetland bund by nature experts in rotation. After the walk, the children were introduced to the idea of nature journaling and encouraged to express what they saw and felt on paper through words, drawings, or both.

What did this unexpected blend of alternative pedagogy (nature journaling, observation, smaller group interactions) and mainstream pedagogy (competition, larger groups, structured activity) look like?

As the children sat down to journal, some reached for butterfly guides, so that they could accurately identify and draw the butterflies they had seen, carefully arranging them into neat grids. Others drew free-floating butterflies in every imaginable colour. One child was about to sketch a delicate deveined leaf that had fascinated him during the walk before deciding to draw butterflies, the clear crowd favourite. Others chose not to focus on individual species at all, sketching the wetland as a living landscape: cormorants basking in the sun, fish darting beneath lily pads, dragonflies, trees, and people sharing the same space. Some children worked collaboratively, discussing ideas and encouraging one another, while a few quietly sat alone, carefully drawing what they observed.

i. Held by Kovai Kulangal Padhakappu Maiyam and Care Earth Trust in Vellalore Butterfly Park, Coimbatore on World Wetlands Day 2024.

Those who attended drawing academies demonstrated impressive artistic techniques, using different textures for water and sky. One child wrote vividly about the amazement they felt when a Crimson Rose butterfly landed on their arm.

Alternative educators might question the idea of ranking something as personal as a nature journal within a competition. But mainstream schooling has few entry points for introducing alternative pedagogy, and with competitions being a consistent part of their pedagogy,

there may be value in using such an entry point to allow students to be acquainted with journaling. Even if they all could not "win" nor journal purely for themselves, the children engaged well with the activity. The entries showed that this was not "just" a nature drawing competition. The variety of entries also reflected the influence of different pedagogies. While technical accuracy, neatness, and looking to peers for cues about what to draw are prioritized by mainstream schooling, the children's entries also demonstrated creative freedom, personal observation, stillness, and individual reflection, which are more consistently encouraged within alternative approaches. Most importantly, many students who might not otherwise get the chance to do so, were allowed the time to observe and think about the cormorant they saw, feel awestruck by a butterfly, or be mesmerized by a leaf.

Instead of looking to use one "correct" pedagogy, environmental educators need to ask how different approaches can work together and which design would work best for the diverse needs of students and school contexts they are working with. Furthermore, the observation-led approach of alternative pedagogy can complement mainstream approach's focus on technical knowledge and





vice versa. After all, scientific pursuits emerge at the meeting point of curiosity, observation, and wonder. For example, a [studyⁱⁱ on species literacy](#) suggests that recognizing and identifying plants and animals can foster greater familiarity with Nature and more positive environmental attitudes. Species literacy and technical knowledge of biodiversity can help contribute to the very outcomes alternative pedagogies often value: curiosity, emotional connection, and confidence in engaging with the natural world.

In practice, mainstream educators may treat such nature education as time consuming if it does not result in the reportable outcomes prioritized by schools and school boards. The few mainstream educators who do go above and beyond to facilitate observation-based nature education, may require external help in accessing suitable resources, tools, and related opportunities for their students. The philosophy of alternative pedagogy may also be difficult to integrate into mainstream schools if teachers are positioned merely as unwilling recipients to be lectured to, and if the schools' existing systems of resource allocation aren't taken into account. Another studyⁱⁱⁱ on [learner-centered education reforms in India](#) suggests that educational change is most likely to succeed when educators are treated as active co-creators rather than as passive recipients.

Two approaches that can be considered while tackling this:

- A toolkit developed by Nature Classrooms helps
- ii. Hooykaas M.J.D, Schilthuizen M., Aten C., Hemelaar E.M., Albers C.J., Smeets I. (2019). Identification skills in biodiversity professionals and laypeople: A gap in species literacy. *Biological Conservation*, 238. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.biocon.2019.108202>
- iii. Brinkmann S., (2015). Learner-centred education reforms in India: The missing piece of teachers' beliefs. *Policy Futures in Education*, 13(3). <https://doi.org/10.1177/1478210315569038>

look at the various outcomes of nature education programmes more comprehensively. Called the '[Nature Education Assessment Framework](#)', it offers ways to study outcomes such as emotional connection to the environment through attitudes and behaviours of students, which is commonly overlooked by conventional assessment methods. However, it also makes it clear that it is not an assessment tool for measuring outcomes, but merely for reflecting on how a nature education programme has worked against its goals, both from the students' and educators' perspectives.

- As part of my work in nature education at [Care Earth Trust](#), we prioritized schools that had often had little exposure to nature education. Introduction to pedagogical tools like books and discussing ways of integrating ecological education into the existing school curricula across subjects were some of the ways we approached this with environment educators and decision makers within the school system. Enthusiastic parents who could see the changes and value of such an approach were as instrumental as passionate educators in enabling consistent observation-based learning for their children.

If imagination, curiosity, and inquiry are to become everyday parts of environmental learning, schools and education systems themselves must begin to value them as core educational outcomes with skills that translate at the workplace, and with the ability to create a lasting connection with the environment. If we continue to teach about the environment without acknowledging different pedagogies and student learning profiles, future scientists and policymakers may continue to ask the same questions and arrive at the same answers. Perhaps, systematically giving all students an opportunity to ask unique questions today can help them collectively answer the complex environmental challenges of tomorrow.

Note: Although the terms environment education, nature education, and environmental science education are sometimes used to mean different approaches to environmental learning, in this article they have been used interchangeably as the article seeks to discuss curricular or extracurricular activities by which students learn about the environment.

Sunanda Ramasamy has worked as a project associate at [Care Earth Trust](#). Having a humanities background with a Master's in Urban Policy and Governance, she is interested in urban ecology, communications, sociology, and is a nosy neighbour to the birds visiting her terrace. The author can be reached at [<sunanda.eka@gmail.com>](mailto:sunanda.eka@gmail.com).

Mangroves in the spotlight

Radhika Chhaparia

Mangroves, once mistaken for waste marshy land and even mismanaged as regular forests, are the subject of nearly a dozen Indian children's books today, with several that spotlight this unique ecosystem with accuracy, sensitivity, and vivid storytelling. These books invoke wonder and curiosity about the spectacular biodiversity of mangrove forests and express concern about their vulnerable state, compelling us to ponder the false hierarchy between human and non-human species. Some of these books also recognize children's agency in turning things around for a better future. Cutting across genres and languages, the selection of titles included here deserve the attention of educators looking for children's literature on the topic. However, print versions of tales about mangroves – though not created specifically for children – date at least as far back as the 19th century, when the legend of Bon Bibi was recorded in *dwipodi-poyar*, a Bengali verse meter. So, why not begin there?

Mangroves in folktales and legends

In Bon Bibi's Forest is a retelling of an age-old folktale about the restoration of balance and harmony in the abundant and mysterious forests of the Sundarbans. It also narrates the story of the common cultural

practice of paying respect to Bon Bibi, also known as Ban Durga, before entering the forest to take away only what is needed for human survival. This particular rendition of the tale begins by introducing Dokhkhin Rai (a tiger), the terrifying ruler of the forest, who has taken to feeding on human flesh. One day, he approaches Dhona, a rich merchant in the area, to satiate his hunger. However, Dhona, outwits Dokhkhin Rai and strikes a business deal with him. In exchange for honey and wax, Dhona promises Dokhkhin Rai a palatable dish in the form of a young orphan boy named Dukhey. Dokhkhin Rai keeps his end of the bargain, but when the

time arrives to hand over Dukhey, something extraordinary occurs. Sensing danger to his own life, Dukhey makes an earnest appeal to Bon Bibi, the forest goddess, for protection from Dokhkhin Rai. At this point, the guardians of the forest – Bon Bibi and her twin brother Shah Jongoli – arrive to intervene. Not only do they offer protection to the innocent, they also serve justice to the vulnerable, and remind the greedy of the ethics of the forest. One of the most striking moments in the story is when Bon Bibi acknowledges Dokhkhin Rai's sorry state, which is a direct result of a shortage of prey owing to human excesses. It's a captivating tale that offers a direct opportunity for readers to consider the difference between need and greed, and the relationship between humans, non-humans, and natural resources. The narrative, suitable for primary and middle-school children, also emphasizes Bon Bibi's spiritual significance and the shared cultural relevance of the folktale to both Hindu and Muslim communities living in the region. Originally written in English, the book is available in Bengali, Gujarati, Hindi, Kannada, Malayalam, Marathi, Tamil, and Telugu.

Jungle Nama: A Story of the Sundarban, inspired by the same episode narrated above, is a longer and relatively layered version of the tale. Told in verse, and allegorical in nature, it also features an important additional character named Mona. Where Dhona symbolizes unrestrained capitalist greed, his brother

Mona is comparatively cautious, seemingly content, and fearful of the consequences of unchecked desires. However, his corrupt conscience is not hard to miss, particularly when he aids his brother to set sail for a final loot of treasures from the Sundarbans. Another point of departure in this version is that it is Dhona who trespasses into Dokhkhin Rai's territory, and not the tiger spirit that runs amok for human blood. Nevertheless, Dhona manages to stoke Dokhkhin Rai's greed for human flesh and the two

Image courtesy: Tulika Publishers
(<https://www.tulika-books.com>)

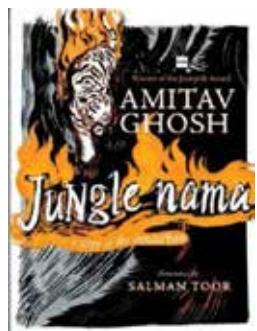


Image courtesy: HarperCollins India

strike their own sweet deal. Expectedly, the guardians of the forest arrive just in time to rescue Dukhey. Bon Bibi comes through not only as the embodiment of justice, balance, and harmony, but also as the voice of restraint for both human and non-human species. The story, narrated in eight chapters, raises far more complex questions about the logic of profit, temptation, morality, contentment, and survival. It's best suited for middle-school children and above. A musical audiobook adaptation of this book is also available and will prove useful for inclusive classrooms and libraries. This book particularly lends itself to a theatre/play adaptation.

Mangroves in creative nonfiction

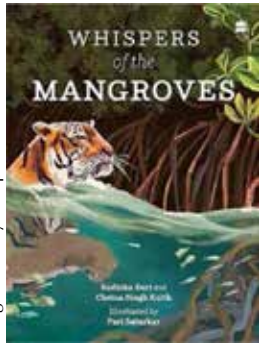


Image courtesy: HarperCollins India

The picture book *Whispers of the Mangroves* conveys the daily rhythm of these magical forests through its lyrical writing and spectacular illustrations. Every single page in the book is throbbing with life and stunning hues, and comes through as deeply respectful of Nature. It introduces readers to this

grand coastal landscape and its biodiversity bit by bit, from the treetops to the mudflats. Interestingly, the human tribe is placed somewhere in the middle of it, seen harvesting honey and fishing, and is as striking and beautiful as the rest of Nature. In a subtle but effective way, this book defies any hierarchical relationship between human and non-human species and avoids any portrayal of human-animal conflict. It's best suited for early readers to encourage curiosity, wonder, and a love for Nature, but it can be relished across all age-groups. It also includes a

map that highlights other mangrove forests across the world.

Mangroves in fictional narratives

Many Secrets of Mangroves, an illustrated short novel, seamlessly combines nonfictional elements with fictional storytelling. Set on an imaginary Mangal Dweep Island, the book is impressively interactive and informative from the get-go. The characters are lovable and the plot is both eventful and lighthearted.

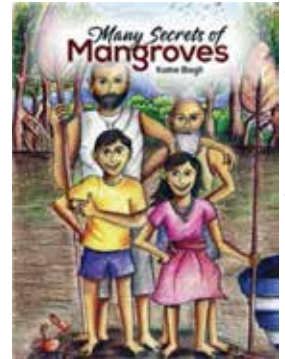
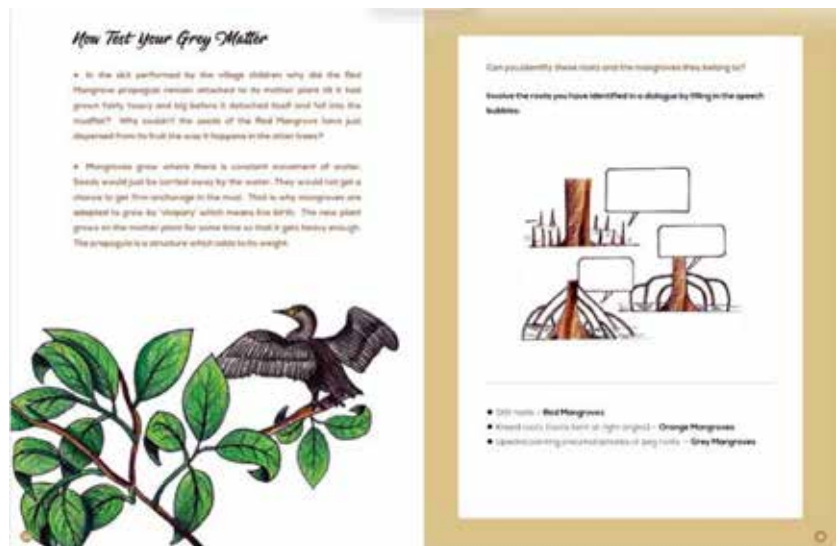


Image courtesy: Godrej & Boyce Mfg. Co. Ltd.

When a recently widowed city-dweller, Ganesh, ventures out to sea with his two children, they get caught in a terrifying storm about a week or so into their voyage. Fortunately, their boat drifts towards calmer shores of the mangrove forests near Mangal Dweep Island. With even better luck, they find safety, hospitality, and adventure in the company of a well-versed and resourceful man named Bauna. From the time they step onto the island, until the time they leave for the city, they get deeply involved in experiencing, exploring, and falling in love with the place, its creatures and its rhythm. From glossy marsh snakes and telescopium shellfish to sponge colonies, they see it all! All along, Bauna encourages the two children, Radhi and Abhay, to consider the ways in which the flora and fauna they encounter there have adapted to the coastal conditions. Each of the eight chapters is educational and ends with an exercise to reinforce facts and concepts. A few exercises also encourage creative responses from children.

This double-spread from 'Many Secrets of Mangroves' directly engages children with what they can infer and have learned about mangrove propagules and roots. It's illustrative of similar exercises included at the end of each chapter.

Image courtesy: Godrej & Boyce Mfg. Co. Ltd.



The author has generously shared trivia about corals, the Sundarbans, water monitor lizards, meswak trees, etc. The book is special because it gives readers a chance to imagine the significance of conservation and restoration of mangrove forests in the context of the day-to-day life of those who occupy these forests. The story portrays a harmonious and conscious local community that deeply loves and cares for their environment. Stunning sketches that complement the author's vivid storytelling truly upholds the saying, "Reading can take you places you have never been before." *Many Secrets of Mangroves* will prove engaging for middle-schoolers, but it appears accessible to the higher grades in primary-school as well. Its Marathi translation is available as 'Karamati Kharphuti'.



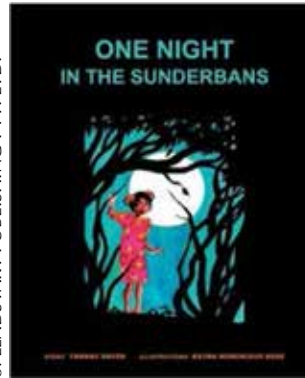
Image courtesy: Karadi Tales Company

Paro of the Sundarbans, a picture book, is a feast for the eyes and offers an engaging way to introduce young readers

to the fauna of the Sundarbans. Paro, a spirited little mudskipper, is lost and anxious to find her way back home before it gets dark and difficult for her to breathe on land. In her quest to return to her family, she encounters different creatures who lend her a helping hand one way or another. Through her adventurous trip, readers get a wondrous tour of the magnificent Sundarbans and a close look at some of the mammals, birds, and reptiles living there. But, does her gutsy venture cause trouble for other young ones? Actually, it turns out quite the contrary! In the hope to explore the vast landscape, several young ones attempt purposeful detours themselves.

Set in a small coastal village named Bonmati in Bengal, *One night in the Sunderbans* is an imaginative chapter book, suitable for both primary and middle-school children. The plot revolves around an eight-year-old girl, Diya, who has grown up at the edge of the forest. One stormy night, when her beloved family goat, Mishti, veers off into the forest, Diya musters courage, seeks Bon Bibi's blessings and ventures alone into the forest in search of Mishti. Diya's fantastical encounters with the king cobra, a mighty crocodile, and expectedly, the royal Bengal tiger that night weave an unforgettable tale. Though the story and the images beautifully bring alive the Sundarbans for the reader, *One Night In The Sunderbans* stands out because of its central

Image courtesy: HAPPY SQUIRREL, an imprint of LEADSTART PUBLISHING PVT. LTD.



theme of conservation and restoration of the Sundarbans, and the voice it grants to non-human species to express their suffering and loss of habitat. In contrast to the tiger spirit Dokhhin Rai, the royal Bengal tiger's avatar in this story is of the wise one, with a palpable softer side.

The Mysterious Mangroves of Bhitarkanika, a novel for middle-graders, highlights both the rewards and challenges faced by communities residing near mangrove forests. In the story, Jehan, a young boy accompanies his father Shapur on his work trip to Dangmal in Odisha, but it soon turns into a vacation straight out of his dreams. Early on, Jehan befriends a local girl named Runu, who takes great pleasure and pride in showing Jehan all the treasures and wonders of her village. Together with Pritesh, a forest staff member, and their guide, the foursome witness a few hair-raising sights, and a few that can be best described as otherworldly. You see, the mangroves of Bhitarkanika are home to the world's largest saltwater crocodiles! They even witness an *arribada*, the annual migratory arrival of the endangered olive ridley turtles to nest on a handful of beaches in Odisha. The story portrays a thoughtful community, where people love and care for mangroves but also feel challenged by the rising human-animal conflict in the wake of developments like dams and the undeniable reality of their shared dependence on fish for survival. While the plot itself is educational in this regard, it also sets the ground to further engage readers to deepen their understanding of human-animal conflict in similar areas and our government's response to it. Just like in *Many Secrets of Mangroves*, here too the author has shared tidbits of relevant trivia and included a few exercises to aid recollection of the fauna and flora encountered in the story. The illustrations in the book not only breathe life into the forests that many of us will likely never see in reality, but also bring the plot alive. The book is available as 'Rahasyamaya Hentalban' in Odia.



Image courtesy: MoEF&CC, Mangroves Forest Division Rajnagar (Odisha Forest Department) and GIZ India on behalf of IKI – BMUKN



The novel *Down by the Mangroves* not only captures the ebb and flow of life in the villages located in the buffer and fringe areas of the Sundarbans, but also tells the heart-wrenching story of how Moyna, a preteen girl, loses her father to a tiger. Rattled by the news, caught in disbelief and struggling to accept her father's passing, Moyna's entire

world comes to a standstill once she realizes that her *Baba* will never return home. She finds some comfort in the company of her friend Sumi, who lost her father similarly, and therefore, knows the pain all too well. Moyna's mother, who's as grief-stricken by the loss and also has to bear the stigma of being a 'tiger widow', never gives up on her. She gently nudges Moyna to take baby steps towards returning to life the way it was before they were struck by the tragedy. Ironically, Moyna finds the courage to return to school by hiding behind her father's mask, the one that he used to put on during village festivals while performing the role of Dokkhin Rai, the tiger-spirit of the Sundarbans. Slowly, with the unwavering support of her Ma, Sumi, teachers, and Salaam kaka, Moyna regains her strength to get on with life. But most of all, it is the realization of an eternal bond with her *Baba*, his songs, his words and dreams for Moyna that cause her spirit and smile to return. In a single stroke, this tender story illustrates human resilience, human-animal conflict, and the reciprocal relationship between humans and Nature. The plot is enriched by references to cultural practices of the region and well-complemented by illustrations that bring Moyna's village and many of the characters to life. The novel is recommended for middle-school children.

Developed as part of KATHA's Adivasi and Dalit Lab (KADL) initiative, *Finding Tree* is a fantastical tale set in an Irula community. This picture book, consisting of eight short chapters, tells the story of a young girl, Nachiketaki, who wakes up to find that her beloved mangrove tree has disappeared overnight. Once she realizes that the tree has passed on to the realm of the dead, her anger is replaced by grief of loss and a

quiet determination to overturn the situation by confronting Emmeraja, the god of death. She takes off on this purposeful journey with a parrot who is equally shattered, having lost



her home and all her babies with it. Nachi travels through extraordinary lands, meets strange but helpful creatures, and finally comes face-to-face with Emmeraja, who appears more like a grandmother to her than anybody else. As the two of them exchange thoughts, questions, and ideas, Nachi is again made to recognize the inevitability of death. But, the idea that those who pass on continue to live within those who love them, fills her with hope. And, in the end, hope proves enough for her to smile again and nurture a mangrove sapling that may one day grow up to be like her Tree. The strength of the story lies in its moving portrayal of the significance of mangroves beyond their material benefits. Nachi's and Parrot's emotional turmoil seem representative of the devastation that communities experience due to the degradation of the mangrove forests on their homeland. Nevertheless, it seems important that while engaging children with this book, educators also highlight that the current loss of the mangrove forests is driven by industry demands, pollution, and rising human consumption, which is a concern that needs to be addressed through human endeavour. Also available in Hindi as '*Ped Ki Khoj Mein*' and as '*Marathai Theydi*' in Tamil, the book seems appropriate for middle-school children.

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Radhika Chhapparia has obtained an MA in Education from Azim Premji University, Bengaluru. For the academic years 2020-23, she worked at Centre for Learning school (CFL), Bengaluru. The author can be reached at radhika.chhapparia16_mae@alumni.apu.edu.in.

How questions can open the door to affirmation

Aruna Sankaranarayanan

In last month's issue, I described the spirit of "motivational interviewing," (MI) a conversation style developed by psychologists William Miller and Stephen Rollick to enhance intrinsic motivation of clients in a clinical context. Today, I discuss two interviewing skills used by MI practitioners that can be very useful to teachers in classrooms – asking open-ended questions and affirming students.

Coaxing deep and divergent thinking

Open-ended questions, unlike closed ones, invite a range of responses and typically require some time for reflection before a person can answer them. In their book, *Motivational Interviewing*, Miller and Rollick compare open-ended questions to an open door. In a classroom, this gateway metaphor welcomes students to engage in exploratory thinking.

When introducing a topic, teachers can help students connect with it by asking open-ended questions. For example, before introducing set theory to a class of eighth-graders, the teacher may ask the class, "In what ways do you think you are similar and different from your friends?" This question doesn't have a single right answer and may prompt a number of responses. After getting a few students to share their views, the teacher may introduce sets as a way of organizing and making sense of disparate information that students have provided.



Image generated using AI

While close questions that have a single right answer definitely have a place in a classroom, they may be interspersed with open questions to both engage students and deepen understanding. As most close questions may be answered through rote learning, open questions allow students to reveal their thinking. As a result, both students and teachers may discover lacunae in the students' understanding that can then be addressed.

For example, if you are discussing the structure and function of plant and animal cells, an open question may ask, "What are the main differences between plant and animal cells and why do you think those differences exist?" This type of question not only requires the student to demonstrate their knowledge of the structure of plant and animal cells, it also requires them to exhibit their reasoning skills. If you want students to exert their creativity, you could ask, "If you had to design a "hybrid cell" that combines features from both plant and animal cells, what structures would you pick and why?"

Open-ended questions also stimulate group discussion. As they don't have a singular correct answer, each student may be invited to share their unique perspective. Further, as most such questions cannot be answered by one-word responses, students learn to articulate themselves and hone their communication skills. By dividing the class into smaller groups, teachers can coax every child to participate and provide their views about an issue. Open-ended questions allow students to examine topics from multiple lenses, broadening their worldviews.

Attune to the positive

It's not enough to ask open questions. How we respond to students also matters. If we want to embody the principles of MI, we need to affirm each student. This involves recognizing each student as a person with "inherent worth." In competitive classrooms that mirror the rat race of modern life, marks and grades take centre stage, often at the expense of genuine understanding. Further, students who are not academically proficient may feel disparaged by a system that doesn't recognize their personhood.

So, how can teachers affirm each student? When students speak, we need to listen to understand. We need to convey our intent, both through our words and body language, that every student has something valuable to contribute. Further, we need to listen with an open mind; if we view students solely through an evaluative lens, we may fail to connect with them.

If students excel at the subject we teach, we may pinpoint their specific and singular strengths. For example, "Leena, you use words precisely and powerfully," "Rahul, you have a knack for deciphering different operations involved in multi-step problems," or "Anjum, your ability to distil the main arguments from the readings is commendable." While it's relatively easy to affirm students who display strengths in the subjects you teach, what about students who are struggling in them?

To gain a more rounded view of students, it's helpful to observe them through a wider lens. Sheeba may struggle to master multiplication tables but you notice that she's the first one to share her stationery with friends. While Rohan may find it difficult to write a coherent paragraph, you find that his handwriting is beautiful. Alina cannot solve quadratic equations, however, you find that she can solve interpersonal issues with friends with elan. Even if students are doing poorly in a subject, you can affirm their generosity, penmanship, or negotiation skills.

Whenever time permits, you may talk to students one-on-one to find out about their interests, hobbies, goals, and dreams. When opportunities arise, affirm the varied talents and passions of individual students to the class. If you see children as persons of "inherent worth," chances are that they too will start noticing and appreciating qualities in one another and in themselves as well.

Aruna Sankaranarayanan is a visiting faculty member at the School of Education, Azim Premji University and the co-author of *Bee-witched* with Brinda S. Narayan. The author blogs at www.arunasankaranarayanan.com.

How teacher wellbeing and SEL practices shape effective classrooms

Neha Singh

Step into any English-medium school in a small Indian town and you'll see teachers wearing multiple hats – educator, mentor, counsellor, sometimes even parent-figure. Parents today see English proficiency and exam performance as gateways to opportunity and eventually a successful future. But behind the neat uniforms and disciplined assemblies lies a different story: teachers navigating high expectations while receiving minimal emotional support themselves.

In many small-town schools, staff rooms hum with lesson planning, exam timetables, parent meetings,

and administrative demands. Yet, one critical factor rarely makes it into those discussions – the emotional wellbeing of teachers.

The *Teachers' Mental Well-being Survey 2024* conducted by NCERT, involving 71,635 teachers from across 28 states and 8 union territories, reinforces what education scholars from around the world have been saying: a teacher's mental and emotional health shapes the entire classroom climate, impacting student engagement, discipline, academic outcomes, and even creativity. "When teachers feel overwhelmed or undervalued, that stress seeps into



their interactions with students. But when they feel supported and emotionally balanced, even the most modest classroom transforms into a space of safety, inspiration, and belonging,” (NCERT). Ironically, while Social-Emotional Learning (SEL) programmes are gradually being introduced for students in Indian schools, teachers themselves rarely receive the same training, coaching, or emotional support. They are expected to model empathy, resilience, and positivity without being equipped with the tools to sustain those qualities themselves.

The question thus is: How can we expect effective teaching when the teacher’s emotional tank is running empty?

The missing link – teacher wellbeing

Teaching goes far beyond crafting lesson plans or correcting papers – it demands emotional labour, empathy, responsiveness, and relational agility. In small towns, where resources are limited and roles overlap, teachers often double as untrained counsellors, unwilling disciplinarians, and unmotivated community mentors. Behind the vibrant bulletin boards and organized lesson files lies a widespread, under-acknowledged reality: burnout, stress, and societal pressures that frequently leave teachers emotionally drained. According to the NCERT survey, many teachers report anxiety, exhaustion, and a lack of institutional support – factors linked to difficulty in classroom management and declining job satisfaction.

Looking beyond national data, we find support in broader literature:

- A systematic review of 44 studies (Dreer et al., 2023) showed consistent positive associations between teacher wellbeing and beneficial outcomes such as stronger teacher-student relationships, teacher retention, and improved student outcomes.
- In India, “*Enhancing Psychological Well-Being of School Teachers*” by Chaudhry et al. (2023) explores how stress, energy management, and thriving dynamics influence psychological wellbeing among Indian teachers. It underscores that in Indian settings, teachers face high demands inside the classroom, along with carrying administrative burdens and expectations beyond their role.
- During the COVID-19 pandemic, a study of low-income Indian schools (Gavade et al.) showed how teachers, in the absence of structured emotional support systems, built informal

support networks for coping – often mediated via smartphones – but still reported emotional strain and isolation.

- The *Saharaline* intervention (Varanasi et al., 2024) is a pilot example: a WhatsApp-based support system for teachers in Indian low-resource schools that offers domain-specific emotional, pedagogical, and technological help. Though small in scale, it demonstrates that local, contextualized emotional support models are possible and effective.

These studies align in demonstrating a core truth: teacher wellbeing is not a peripheral concern – it is deeply tied to how classrooms thrive. In small-town English-medium schools, where support systems are fewer and pressures magnified, the consequences of neglecting teacher wellbeing are felt more acutely.

When teachers run on empty tanks, classrooms begin to mirror that fatigue. Students sense it, engagement dips, responsiveness wanes, and the warmth of learning can give way to bare minimum transactional syllabus delivery with minimal learning taking place.

SEL beyond students – why teachers need it too

SEL refers to cultivating self-awareness, emotional regulation, empathy, relationship skills, and responsible decision-making. Traditionally, SEL is framed in student development – but teachers, too, can adopt these competencies for themselves.

How SEL practices benefit teachers

- **Emotional regulation:** Teachers who pause, name their feelings, and respond intentionally can reduce reactive teaching.
- **Self-awareness and reflection:** Understanding one’s stress triggers or emotional fatigue enables proactive coping.
- **Empathy and relational skills:** Help build strong teacher-student, teacher-parent, and teacher-colleague connections.
- **Responsible decision-making:** Teachers can set boundaries around workload or select strategies aligned with their energy.

Simple SEL practices for teachers

- **Mindfulness micro-breaks:** One deep breathing or grounding exercise between classes.
- **Emotional check-ins:** A brief “how am I feeling?” at the start or end of the day.
- **Reflective journalling:** Noting one success and one challenge each day.



- **Peer-support circles:** Sharing challenges, strategies, and encouragement with trusted colleagues.

When teachers internalize SEL, they become more resilient in the face of stress, better able to navigate classroom disruptions, and more consistent in their professional identity and motivation.

The ripple effect on students

Teachers who carry emotional balance and authenticity into their classrooms create an environment of psychological safety. When students feel seen, heard, and emotionally secure, academic risk-taking, collaboration, and creativity naturally increases.

How does this manifest

- **Modelling emotional responses:** When conflicts or mistakes arise, a calm, empathetic response from the teacher becomes the behavioural script students internalize.
- **Consistency and predictability:** Emotionally stable teachers handle disruptions with

composure – students feel safer, discipline issues reduce.

- **Emotional climate:** A classroom where the teacher is present and emotionally regulated tends to harbour trust, openness, and respectful discourse.

Classroom vignette

A student gets upset during a group activity, slamming a pen down. A frustrated teacher might respond sharply, triggering defensiveness. But a teacher trained in SEL pauses, acknowledges the student's feelings ("I see this is frustrating"), and invites the student to articulate the cause. The moment of de-escalation then doubles as a teaching moment – students see conflict handled respectfully, and the overall class tone resets.

In essence, students don't just learn content – they absorb emotional norms. Teachers who practice SEL, provide an invisible curriculum of emotional literacy by example.

From theory to practice – what schools can do

If teacher wellbeing and SEL are critical, how can schools support this in realistic, sustainable ways?

Practical quick tips for teachers

- **Start small:** One 60-second breathing exercise before class.
- **Emotional check-ins:** Use a 1-5 scale during morning staff huddles (“How are you feeling today?”).
- **Reflective journalling:** Each Saturday, write down one success for the week and one struggle for the week gone by, and one intention for the coming week.
- **Set boundaries:** Learn to say “not now” to tasks that encroach on personal time.
- **Pair with a colleague:** Check in weekly about emotional wellbeing and share strategies.
- **Micro-meditations:** Even in two minutes between classes, pause and ground yourself.
- **Gratitude rituals:** Begin or end the day by naming someone or something in your school that you appreciate.

Implementing even one or two of these practices notches up resilience; over time, they become protective habits.

Integrate wellbeing into teacher training and induction

- Embed SEL modules in pre-service and in-service teacher programmes.
- Offer workshops on emotional self-care, stress management, peer coaching, and reflective practice.

Build internal support structures

- **Mentorship and peer coaching:** Pair newer teachers with empathetic, more experienced mentors.
- **Wellness workshops and retreats:** Occasional off-site or half-day sessions focused on emotional refresh, team building, or micro-resilience practices.
- **Counselling support:** Partner with local mental health professionals or NGOs to provide on-call support or digital check-ins.

Leadership and policy alignment

- School leadership must affirm wellbeing as part of institutional priorities, not just academics.

- Reduce administrative burden where possible; delegate or streamline paperwork.
- Establish an allocated “buffer time” for teachers’ emotional check-ins, planning, or peer collaboration.
- Include wellbeing metrics (teacher satisfaction, stress levels) in internal review cycles.

Contextual innovations and low-cost interventions

- Leverage technology: WhatsApp groups or teacher helplines modelled on *Saharaline* to provide micro-support in remote areas.
- Create “emotional corner” spaces or bulletin boards where teachers can post reflections or gratitude notes.
- Introduce periodic “wellbeing days” with no meetings, only collaboration and rest.
- Foster a culture of recognition – small gestures (thank-you notes, peer shout-outs) can have a big emotional impact.

Some small-town schools may face resource constraints, but the real game-changer isn’t always funding – it’s empathy from the school leadership, management, and promoters. Many of these wellbeing initiatives cost little or nothing; what they truly require is a leadership culture that values teachers as people first, professionals second. When school heads and promoters lead with empathy – listening to teachers, acknowledging their emotional load, and acting on their needs – it sets the tone for a supportive, thriving school environment where both teachers and students can flourish.

Conclusion: a classroom that breathes

Teachers are not just carriers of the curriculum – they are the heartbeat of the classroom, the emotional anchors who shape its soul. When we choose to invest in their wellbeing, we’re not just supporting teachers, we are safeguarding the future of education itself.

Because, a teacher who feels valued, heard, and emotionally supported doesn’t just teach – they ignite minds, nurture hearts, and breathe life into learning spaces. And when SEL practices and teacher wellbeing form the very foundation of a classroom, learning stops being mechanical.

Neha Singh is Director, St. Kabir’s School and Siddharth International School, Hisar. The author can be reached at <nehasingh.sanskriti@gmail.com>.

Assessment or control

The fear curriculum we refuse to name

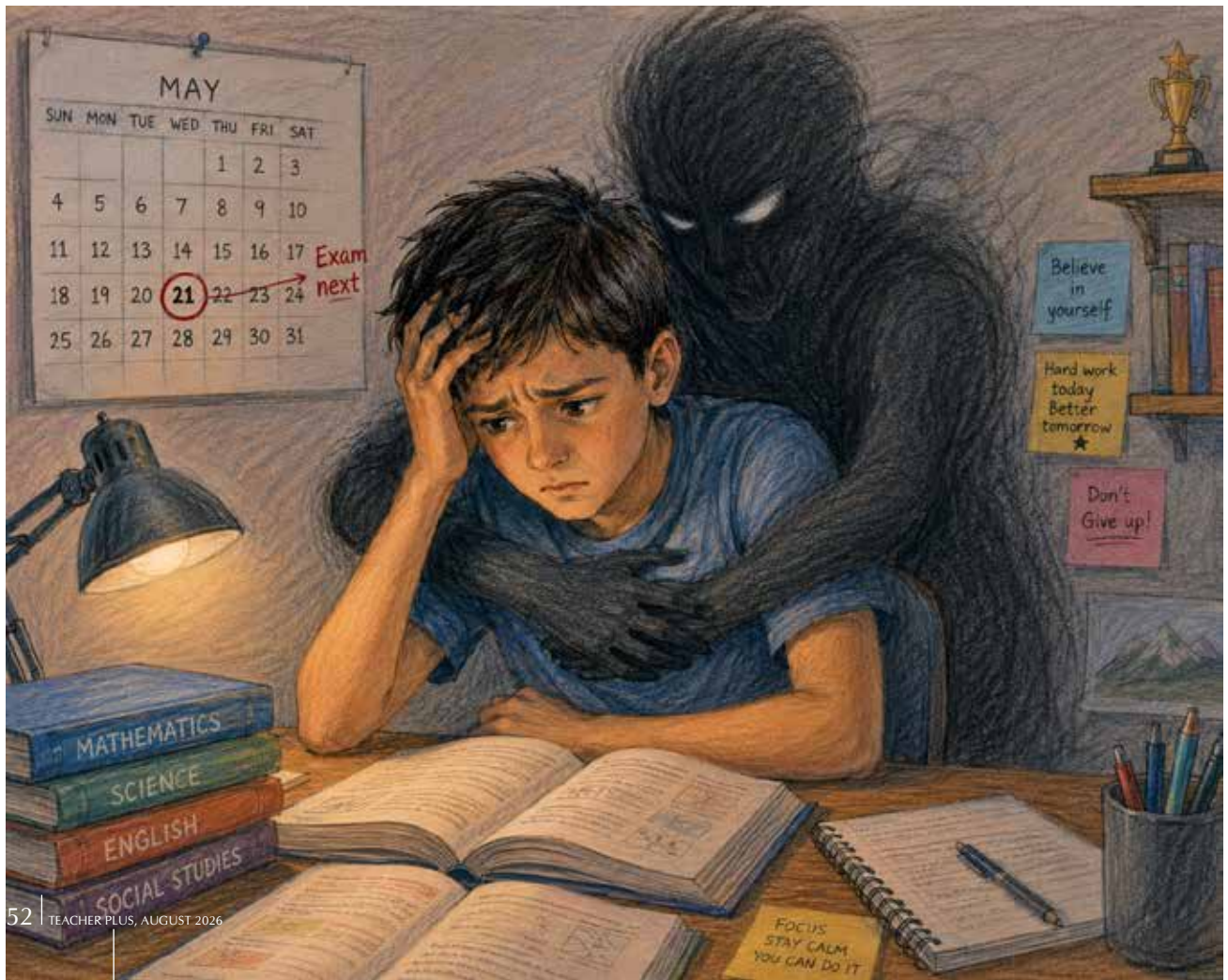
Manisha Pundir

Their hearts pound as the teacher walks in with the question papers. Not because the students are unprepared – but because they know what is at stake. A single exam can decide their confidence, their label in the staffroom, their “rank” in the lobby, and sometimes their value at home. This is not learning. This is conditioning.

Assessments have ceased to be a pedagogical tool. They have become an instrument of control. We do not assess to understand learners; we assess to

rank, sort, and silence them. Let us stop pretending otherwise. From their formative years, students are trained for examinations, not understanding. “Important questions” replace inquiry. “Write exactly like the answer key” replaces thinking.

Coaching centres reinforce classroom priorities, and teachers, often half-heartedly, become invigilators of a system they did not design. Boards speak the language of competency-based education, yet reward rote precision. Schools advertise holistic



development while circulating rank lists. Teachers talk about growth mindset but deduct marks for creative deviation. The hypocrisy is institutional. We say assessment is necessary. But, what we practice is not assessment – it's surveillance.

Unit tests, pre-boards, mock exams, weekly tests – layer upon layer of high-stakes pressure, all justified in the name of "preparation." More than half of the academic days are dedicated to testing students' compliance in protracted assessment days. Learning is reduced to superficial transaction and can even become a liability.

Research suggests that learning flourishes in low-stakes environments, where mistakes are not failures but data for feedback. Pedagogy is equally clear: assessment should inform instruction, reveal misconceptions, and respond to learner diversity. Yet, our classrooms do the opposite. We punish errors, reward conformity, and glorify speed and recall.

Students consistently learn the hidden curriculum: Don't think. Don't ask. Don't take risks. Just obey. The real curriculum is fear.

Teachers are not exempt from this system – they are trapped in it. Pressured by boards, managements, parental expectations, and comparison metrics, teachers often assess not because it helps learning, but because the system demands documentation, numbers, and the testimony of "rigour".

Marks become currency. Ranks become marketing. Children become data points. And in this transaction, we lose something irreparable: meaning.

An education system obsessed with scores will never produce reflective citizens. It will produce compliant test-takers and 'docile bodies'* who know how to

*French philosopher Michel Foucault introduced the concept of "**docile bodies**" in his 1975 book *Discipline and Punish*. It describes how modern institutions – such as schools, prisons, and hospitals – train individuals to be obedient, useful, and productive, not through physical force, but through continuous, subtle control of their time, space, and movements.

follow patterns but hesitate to question them. We are not preparing learners for life; we are preparing them for the next exam. If assessment continues to function as a judge giving verdicts rather than leading to dialogue, control rather than care, then let us at least be honest about it. Let us stop rephrasing the process by using the language of learning to justify practices that are actively detrimental.

The question is no longer what we assess or how we assess, but why we are so afraid to change it. Because when assessments no longer instill fear, power shifts from the system back to the learner. And that, perhaps, is what truly unsettles us.

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Note: This article draws on sustained classroom practice and reflective engagement with assessment cultures in secondary school education. AI tools were used for language refinement and editorial support.

Manisha Pundir is an educator, writer, and research enthusiast based in India, currently serving as Head of the Social Science Department at VidyaGyan School, Sitapur. Her writing explores pedagogy, assessment, and educational change through classroom practice and reflection. Her work has appeared in Teacher Acer, and she has presented research at international academic forums, including IAFOR. The author can be reached at <manisha.pundir87@gmail.com>.

Designing efficient language systems

Grammar and vocabulary

Sanjhee Gianchandani

Grammar and vocabulary are often seen as the easiest parts of language teaching. After all, we have been teaching them for donkeys' years, and most of us feel confident that we know how they "should" be done. Yet, this very familiarity can be misleading. When we pause to reflect on classroom practice, it becomes clear that much of what we routinely do is not entirely aligned with how language is actually learned or used.

Research and classroom experience consistently show that grammatical understanding develops most effectively when it is rooted in meaningful context. To be specific, Myhill, Jones, Lines, and Watson (2012) found that grammar teaching was most effective when it was embedded within meaningful writing instruction rather than taught as isolated rules. This principle is clearly reflected in international curricula and examination boards, which rarely publish separate grammar textbooks. Instead, they offer integrated student books, teacher guides, and workbooks, where grammar and vocabulary emerge naturally from reading texts and listening to them. In contrast, in India, there remains a strong emphasis on syntactic awareness rather than linguistic output. Students are often highly skilled at identifying structures, naming tenses, and correcting sentences on paper, yet far less confident when asked to use the same language in real communication. Grammar becomes something to analyze rather than a resource to express meaning.

K Elango, a retired Professor of English and National Secretary of English Language Teaching Association of India (ELTAI), in his paper, 'Why we need to change our approach to teaching English' mentions how in informal settings such as homes or any non-institutionalized contexts, grammar takes a backseat, facilitating smoother and quicker language acquisition. The insistence on grammar, particularly in institutionalized settings, reveals a distortion in the cognitive process, be it the mother tongue or other languages. Recognizing this, educational curricula introduce the grammar of the mother tongue at a later stage; even then, learners tend to be averse to studying components. In our pedagogy, contrary to real-life ecosystems, the introduction of the language and grammar of English occurs almost simultaneously, as if learners could acquire the language through grammar. This ignores the truth that grammar is about the language, not the language itself. As learners advance through their educational journey, many may rattle off grammatical rules but struggle to produce meaningful linguistic output. However, grammarians and theoreticians characterize grammar as the 'backbone' of language, deeming it more critical than the flesh and blood of language, and their overemphasis on 'accuracy' during the initial phases hampers the learning process.

Let us examine in detail how this distortion happens at a molecular level. Examining a popular grade 5 English textbook:

A preposition is a word or group of words used before a noun, noun phrase, or pronoun to show place, position, time, or method.

Fill in the blanks using the correct prepositions.

Prepositions of Time	Prepositions of Place	Prepositions of Movement
show the time of an action	show where something or someone is	show movement to or from a place
at, in, on, before, after, during, for, since, to, until	at, in, on, under, above, behind, in front of, over, between, below, beside	towards, into, onto, through, across, up, down

in to behind under since

- Amir had made it _____ the last dozen.
- His parents went to Germany _____ September.
- He was standing _____ the door.
- It has been raining _____ last night.
- She is hiding _____ the table.

This material is intended for grade 5 learners, yet it contains several critical pedagogical flaws. The explanations are overly technical and abstract, offering no examples drawn directly from the accompanying text. At this level, such an approach places unnecessary cognitive load on learners and risks producing confusion rather than achieving clarity. Furthermore, the absence of visual support is particularly problematic. For grade 5 students, concepts such as prepositions, especially those of place and movement, should be supported by clear illustrations. The practice component is also insufficient. With only five sentences and a single task, learners are given limited opportunity to notice patterns, practise meaningfully, and consolidate understanding. Effective grammar instruction at the primary level requires multiple, varied practice

opportunities that move from guided to more independent use.

Globally, teaching practices have evolved significantly and English Language Teaching has transformed from a system focused on isolated rules and exercises into a dynamic discipline centred on functionality and communicative purpose. Language forms are now understood as tools for meaning rather than ends in themselves.

With this in mind, let us now examine a more effective example – one that aligns age-appropriate input, visual support, and purposeful practice for grade 4 learners. The text is based on the life of Dr APJ Abdul Kalam.

Grammar

Order of Adjectives

Adjectives describe nouns or pronouns. They tell *what kind*, *which one*, or *how many*.

- APJ Abdul Kalam was a brilliant scientist. (What kind)
- APJ Abdul Kalam was the first President from Tamil Nadu. (Which one)
- APJ Abdul Kalam gave three inspiring speeches yesterday. (How many)

When using more than one adjective before a noun, follow this natural order: opinion -> size -> colour

1. Identify the adjectives used in the following sentences and write down the type.

Sentences	Adjective	Type
a. A P J Abdul Kalam was a gifted student.		
b. Dr Kalam was born on a small island.		
c. He lived in a large family.		
d. He was born on the conch-shaped island of Rameswaram.		
e. He was known as a good President.		

2. The following adjectives describe the animals in the Molai forest. Put them in the correct order. Frame sentences using each set of words.

big golden scary tiger

brown small playful monkey

pale bulky vulture

big grey elephant

white cute tiny rabbit

3. Write one sentence for each of the descriptions given below. Don't forget to put the adjectives in the correct order.
- Nitu sat down in the big chair. It was brown. It was comfortable.
 - Bamboos are tall plants. They are green in colour. They are pretty.
 - Rhinos are strong animals. They are grey in colour.
 - Children love the red and black engines in the railway museum. The engines are huge.
 - The Elephanta caves are full of black stone statues. They are wonderful.

With the kind of integrated textbooks mentioned earlier, it is entirely possible to teach grammar in a way that promotes linguistic efficiency and meaningful language use. A step-by-step approach can help structure lessons and ensure learners fully internalize grammatical concepts:

1. Sift examples from reading or listening input

Begin by identifying examples of the target structure in texts or audio. This helps learners place the grammar in context, see accurate examples, and start recognizing similar structures cognitively.

2. Explain the concept

Use explainer videos, whiteboard techniques, graphic organizers, and the textbook to clarify the meta-language. Provide ample examples so that the definition does not remain abstract or isolated in students' minds.

3. Elicit examples from students

Encourage learners to generate their own examples and write them on the board. This signals the start of cognitive processing and helps learners connect the new structure to their own language.

4. Drill rules

Some structures, such as converting direct to indirect speech or transforming sentences from active to passive voice, may benefit from focused drills. Use this step selectively.

5. Guided practice

Provide exercises with sufficient scaffolding, such as giving word banks, solved examples, hints, or clues, so that learners can attempt tasks with confidence. This is also a good stage to introduce grammar games to make practice engaging.

6. Use authentic resources

While many Indian schools still rely on *Wren & Martin*, on many counts it can be outdated or imprecise. Consider incorporating modern and accurate reference books into your teaching and library:

- *Practical English Usage* by Michael Swan: <https://url-shortener.me/9AJU>
- *Grammar for English Language Teachers* by Martin Parrott: <https://url-shortener.me/9AK2>
- *English Grammar in Use* by Raymond Murphy: <https://url-shortener.me/9AKD>

7. Feedback

Provide timely clarification of misconceptions, correct errors, resolve doubts, and reinforce understanding before moving forward.

8. Unguided practice

Once learners are confident, assign exercises that can be attempted independently. These can be more application-based, such as sentence transformation or rewriting sentences with changed word forms.

9. Revisit

After completing exercises, review and summarize the new concept to reinforce learning and consolidate understanding.

10. Consolidate

Use proven strategies, such as exit tickets, mini-quizzes, or quick reflective tasks, to solidify the concept in students' minds.

A wide range of traditional ELT games can be effectively used to teach grammar. These games are highly versatile and can be adapted to reinforce different structures and concepts. A few popular game titles are listed on the next page; you can search online for instructions and the materials required to play each game.

- Taboo • Find Someone Who • Bingo • Pictionary/Reverse Pictionary • Mime • Doughnut • Hot Seat
- Charades • Fishmarket • Two Truths and a Lie • Running Dictation • Slam • JAM • Hangman/Snowman
- Hot Potato • Simon Says • 20 Questions • Stand up if you... • Chain Story • Relays • Who Am I?
- Spelling Bee • Chinese Whispers • Sentence Scramble • Scavenger Hunt • Show and Tell • Scattergories
- Beep • Rapid Fire Think Fast • Jeopardy • Story Cubes • Would You Rather • Tic-tac-toe

Let us now turn our attention to vocabulary tasks. Ironically, vocabulary development is widely recognized as one of the most critical aspects of language learning, particularly in developing countries such as India. Yet, in practice, it often receives minimal emphasis in textbooks and is sometimes omitted entirely due to space constraints or curriculum limitations.

Consider a popular English coursebook for grade 6. In this example, vocabulary items have not been

drawn from the reading text. This is a clear instance of forced insertion – teaching vocabulary in isolation, disconnected from the text, which can lead to conceptual fragmentation and impede meaningful learning. Furthermore, the subsequent topic, collective nouns, is introduced abruptly, without any transition, context, or link to the preceding material. There are neither explanations nor illustrative examples, leaving learners without guidance or scaffolding.

Abbreviations v/s Acronyms

Read the following.

- Mister can be shortened to Mr.
- The full form of LASER is Light Amplification by Stimulated Emission of Radiation.

Long names or phrases are often shortened by only using the letters of the words such as Mr for Mister. This is an abbreviation of the name or phrase. Sometimes the abbreviation may itself form a word, such as LASER. Then it is called an acronym.

All acronyms are abbreviations, but all abbreviations are not acronyms.

1. Read the following short forms. Write ABV if it is an abbreviation and ACR if it is an acronym.

- ASAP _____
- St. _____
- Wed _____
- No. _____
- tsp _____
- Visa _____
- E.g. _____
- SAARC _____

2. Fill in the blanks with the correct collective nouns.

- A group of fish is called a _____
- A group of islands is called a _____
- A group of musicians is called a _____
- A group of crows is called a _____
- A group of currency notes is called a _____
- A group of acrobats is called a _____

Now, let us examine a well-designed vocabulary section from the chapter *The Diary of Anne Frank* (excerpt). Unlike the previous example, this section integrates vocabulary directly from the text, providing meaningful context, clear examples, and structured exercises that reinforce both comprehension and production.

Vocabulary

Collocations

Collocations are predictable word combinations that native speakers store and use as single units of meaning, rather than creating them word by word. Choosing the correct collocation is about convention, not grammar rules, and using the wrong combination often sounds unnatural even if it is grammatically correct.

Let us see more examples from the text you just read:

- seek refuge (not *find refuge*)
- face danger (not *meet danger*)
- maintain secrecy (not *keep secrecy*)
- endure hardship (not *suffer hardship*)
- write a diary (not *do a diary*)
- lose freedom (not *miss freedom*)

Learning collocations helps writers express ideas more precisely and sound more natural, especially when describing intense experiences.

A. Match the verbs and nouns to form correct collocations

No.	Verb	Noun
1.	seek	a. freedom
2.	face	b. refuge
3.	write	c. danger
4.	break	d. rules
5.	endure	e. hardship
6.	lose	f. silence
7.	remain	g. hopeful
8.	maintain	h. secrecy

B. Use the collocations you formed in Task 1 to fill in the blanks. Use each collocation once only.

1. During the war, many Jewish families had to _____ to stay safe.
2. Everyone living in the annex had to _____ because discovery could be fatal.
3. Anne continued to _____ to express her thoughts and feelings.
4. Even children were forced to _____ in order to survive.
5. Life in hiding meant the family had to _____ for long periods of time.
6. Because of the occupation, Anne felt she had _____ at a very young age.
7. Despite the fear and danger, Anne tried to _____.
8. The family had to _____ at all times to avoid being discovered.

C. Rewrite the sentences using the correct collocations.

1. Anne tried to do hope even in very dark times.
2. Jewish families were forced to take injustice under Nazi rule.
3. Anne wanted to write events honestly in her diary.
4. The family managed to live hardship for more than two years.
5. Living in hiding caused Anne to make isolation from the outside world.
6. Many families had to do sacrifices during the war.

For vocabulary, as with grammar, establishing context through reading or listening input is essential. Context helps learners understand not just the meaning of words, but also their usage, connotations, and collocations. Teaching vocabulary in isolation often leads to shallow learning, whereas connecting words to authentic texts promotes deeper understanding and retention.

The following steps outline an effective approach to teaching vocabulary:

1. Set the context and pre-teach vocabulary related to it

Before reading, establish the historical and emotional context of the text. For example, if students are reading *The Diary of Anne Frank*, they will likely encounter words such as 'persecution', 'curfew', and 'attic'. Pre-teach these items briefly so students can follow the text without confusion.

2. Use student-friendly definitions, models, and examples

When introducing 'attic' or 'refuge', provide simple definitions supported by examples. For instance, 'attic' can be explained as "the space at the top of a house, just under the roof," followed by a model sentence linked to the story: 'The family stayed hidden in the attic for months.' Take the help of a learner's dictionary for the same.

3. Teach more than meaning: pronunciation, word form, collocation, and synonyms

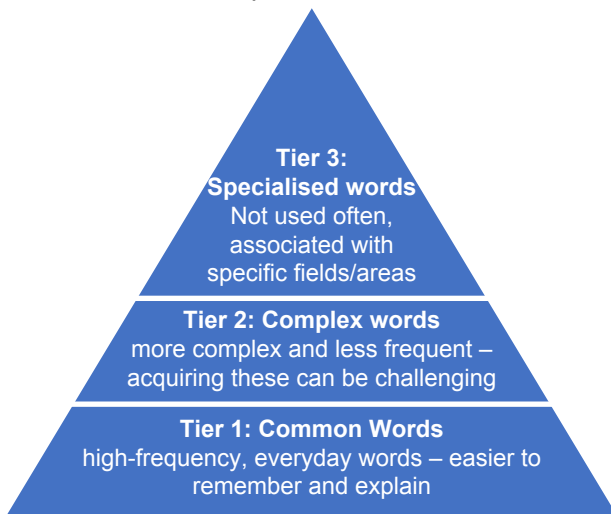
Once the meaning is clear, expand on how the words work. For example, highlight stress in 'persecution', common collocations like 'live in fear' or 'seek refuge', and synonyms such as 'hide' or 'take refuge'.

4. Categorize vocabulary and make relationships visible

Group the target vocabulary on the board or a word wall. For example, 'curfew' and 'persecution' can be placed under "historical restrictions," while 'fear' and 'hope' fall under "emotions and feelings." This helps learners see patterns and themes in the language of the text.

5. Follow the vocabulary tier system

Identify which words are worth deeper focus. For instance, 'house' and 'family' may already be familiar (Tier 1), 'curfew' and 'attic' are topic-specific (Tier 2), while 'persecution' and 'refuge' are high-utility academic words (Tier 3) that deserve extended practice.



6. Use active processing, not just exposure

After presenting the new words 'fear' and 'hope', design a task that requires learners to think about the meaning. For example, students decide which emotion best describes Anne's thoughts in different diary entries or rank moments in the text from most fearful to most hopeful.

7. Make vocabulary multisensory and engaging

Support understanding with visuals and physical context. For example, show photographs of typical European attics from the period to reinforce 'attic', or use short sound clips of silence or distant noise to support understanding of 'fear' and 'tension'.

8. Recycle vocabulary by highlighting it again in the text

As students read the diary excerpt, draw attention to previously taught words when they reappear.

9. Provide ample opportunities for production

After reading, require students to use the target vocabulary. For example, students write a short

diary entry from Anne's perspective, or discuss how betrayal changes the course of the story.

10. Teach and reinforce vocabulary learning strategies

Finally, guide students in recording and reviewing vocabulary from the text. For example, learners add 'endure' to their vocabulary notebooks, including a definition, pronunciation, collocations, and a sentence from *The Diary of Anne Frank*, encouraging independent learning beyond the lesson.

To conclude, rethinking grammar and vocabulary teaching does not mean abandoning structure or accuracy. It means repositioning these language systems as something learners notice, test, and internalize through use. When grammar and lexical resources are extracted from meaningful texts and recycled through purposeful tasks, they stop being floating ideas and become part of the learner's communicative toolkit. Mr Amit Baveja, Managing Director of Burlington English India & Southeast Asia, in an exclusive conversation with news18.com opines, "For children from non-English-speaking homes, fluency starts not with grammar, but with comfort and exposure. Familiarity is key. When English is introduced through songs, stories, and simple conversations, children begin to connect with the language more naturally.... Ultimately, English should be treated as a life skill and a workplace necessity, not just an academic requirement. With that shift, students can step into their careers with far more confidence and capability."

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Sanjeev Gianchandani is an English language materials writer, curriculum designer, and editor. Her extensive experience includes serving as an English language assessment specialist for Trinity College London, assessing various international English language examinations, leading examiner and marker cohorts for Qualifications and Assessments International, UK and developing educational materials for the K-8 segment. Her articles on ELT pedagogy and learning strategies have been published in several educational magazines and blogs. The author can be reached at [<sanjheegianchandani28@gmail.com>](mailto:sanjheegianchandani28@gmail.com).

Why school science needs an Einstein update

Vipin Varghese and David Blair

Most of us who teach science were trained using a familiar framework: forces pull, time ticks uniformly, space is flat, and light behaves like a wave. These ideas have served science well for centuries, but they are no longer our best understanding of how the universe works.

Today's technologies tell a different story. GPS satellites rely on Einstein's relativity to function accurately. Mobile phones, LEDs, solar panels, and medical imaging depend on quantum physics. Even climate science is deeply connected to modern ideas about energy, radiation, and matter.

Yet, in most Indian classrooms, students still encounter a 19th century picture of physics – often

memorized, formula-driven, and disconnected from real life. This gap between *what science knows* and *what schools teach* is one reason many students lose interest in physics during middle school.

Around the world, a growing education initiative called **Einstein-First** is exploring a simple but powerful question:

What if we introduced students to modern physics concepts early, in age-appropriate, activity-based ways, and supported teachers to teach them confidently?

Modern physics is not “too difficult” for children

A common concern among teachers is that ideas like relativity or quantum physics are simply too abstract for school students. Traditionally, these topics are postponed until university because they are mathematically demanding. However, research from the Einstein-First project shows that mathematics is the barrier, not the ideas themselves.

When concepts are taught through models and analogies, using hands-on activities, and with clear, everyday language, children as young as 8 or 9 can meaningfully understand ideas such as:

- light being made of tiny energy packets (photons),
- space being flexible rather than rigid,
- gravity as the curvature of space,
- And uncertainty as a natural part of the microscopic world.

Students often find these ideas more interesting than traditional textbook physics because they feel closer to reality. This approach aligns closely with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020, which emphasizes conceptual understanding, experiential learning, and scientific temper over rote memorization.



Photos courtesy: Vipin Varghese

Students exploring geometry on curved space through an Einstein-First classroom activity.

What is the Einstein-First approach?

Einstein-First is an international education initiative developed collaboratively by The University of Western Australia, Australian National University, Curtin University, and Flinders University. Its goal is not to add more content to the syllabus, but to replace outdated ideas with better ones, taught in developmentally appropriate ways.

Some key features of the approach include:

Learning through activities

Instead of beginning with definitions or equations, lessons start with simple activities. For example, students explore curved surfaces before discussing gravity or build toy models before talking about light.



A LYCRA spacetime sheet helps students visualize gravity as curved, elastic space-time.

Using simple models and toys

Everyday materials such as elastic cloth, marbles, clay, strings, toy cars are used to represent abstract ideas. Students understand that the models are not exact replicas of reality, but they help us think.

Collaborative learning

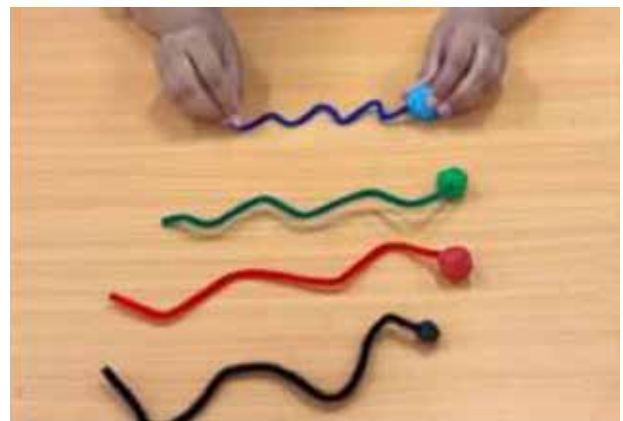
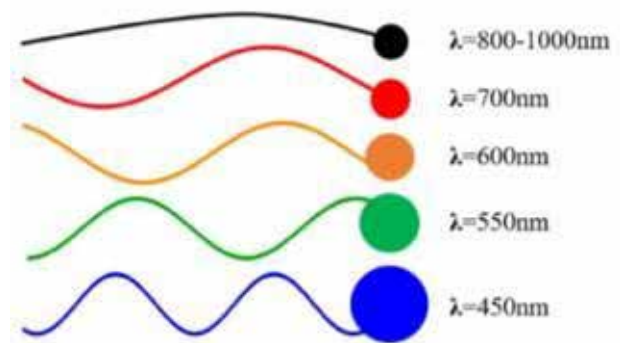
Students work in small groups, discuss observations, and explain ideas to one another. This approach has been shown to be especially supportive for girls and quieter learners.

Honest, clear language

Rather than memorizing technical terms, students use transparent descriptions. For instance, gravity is introduced as “curved space” rather than a mysterious force acting at a distance.

Low-cost and classroom-friendly

All activities are designed to work in the average classroom, including low-resource settings – an important consideration for Indian schools.



“Pet photons” made from clay and string showing light as wave and particle.

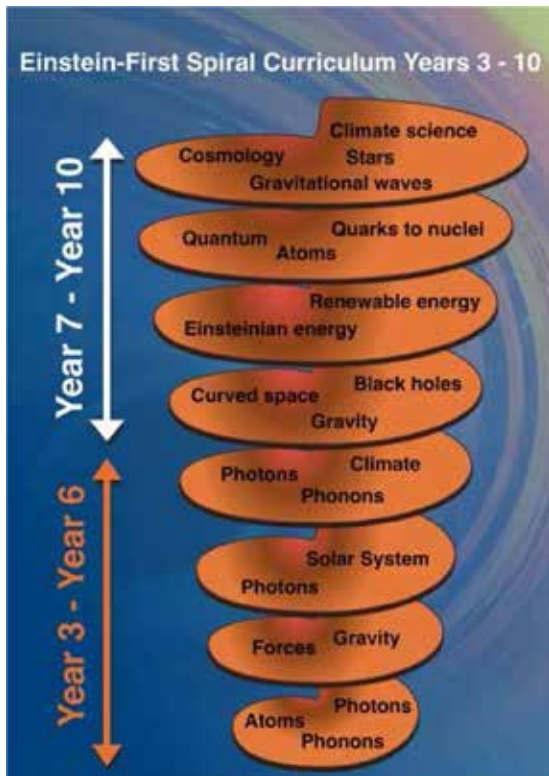
What about teachers?

A crucial insight from Einstein-First is that teachers do not need to be experts in modern physics to teach it well, but they do need support. Many teachers were never formally taught relativity or quantum physics or encountered them only briefly at university. Understandably, this creates hesitation. To address this, the project developed short professional development workshops and [online micro-credential courses](#) that focus on conceptual understanding, model classroom activities, and build confidence step-by-step.

Teachers who complete these courses consistently report reduced anxiety about modern physics, improved understanding and greater enjoyment in teaching science.

This kind of targeted upskilling fits well with NEP 2020’s vision of continuous professional development rather than one-time training.

Why this matters for Indian classrooms



A spiral curriculum showing how Einstein-First concepts develop from years 3 to 10.

India is currently rethinking how science should be taught. Competency-based assessment, interdisciplinary learning, and experiential methods are gaining importance, but curriculum content often remains unchanged.

Introducing Einsteinian ideas early can:

- make science feel relevant and alive,
- help students see connections between school learning and real technology,
- reduce the fear of physics at the secondary level,
- support long-term STEM participation.

Importantly, studies* from Einstein-First classrooms show strong positive responses from girls, challenging long-standing gender stereotypes in physics learning.

Looking ahead

Einstein-First does not aim to turn primary classrooms into university lecture halls. Instead, it asks us to be honest with students about how the world really works, while teaching in ways that respect their developmental stage.

*These are studies from classrooms outside India.



Teachers engaging in hands-on Einstein-First professional learning.

For Indian teachers, this approach offers something refreshing:

- permission to move beyond rigid textbook narratives,
- practical tools for activity-based teaching,
- and confidence that modern science is not beyond the reach of young minds.

As India works toward the goals of NEP 2020, rethinking *what* we teach in science may be just as important as rethinking *how* we teach it. An Einstein-updated view of the universe could be a powerful place to begin.

Acknowledgement

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Dr. David Blair is an Emeritus Professor at the University of Western Australia and Director of the Einstein-First project, which promotes the teaching of modern physics concepts in schools.

Vipin Varghese is an M.Ed. graduate from Tamil Nadu Teachers Education University and a temporary physics teacher at a government school in Kizhakkupuram, Kerala. He is interested in improving physics teaching through innovative classroom practices. The author can be reached at <vipinv_1@yahoo.com>.

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“What exactly are global perspectives?”

A journey from curiosity to connection

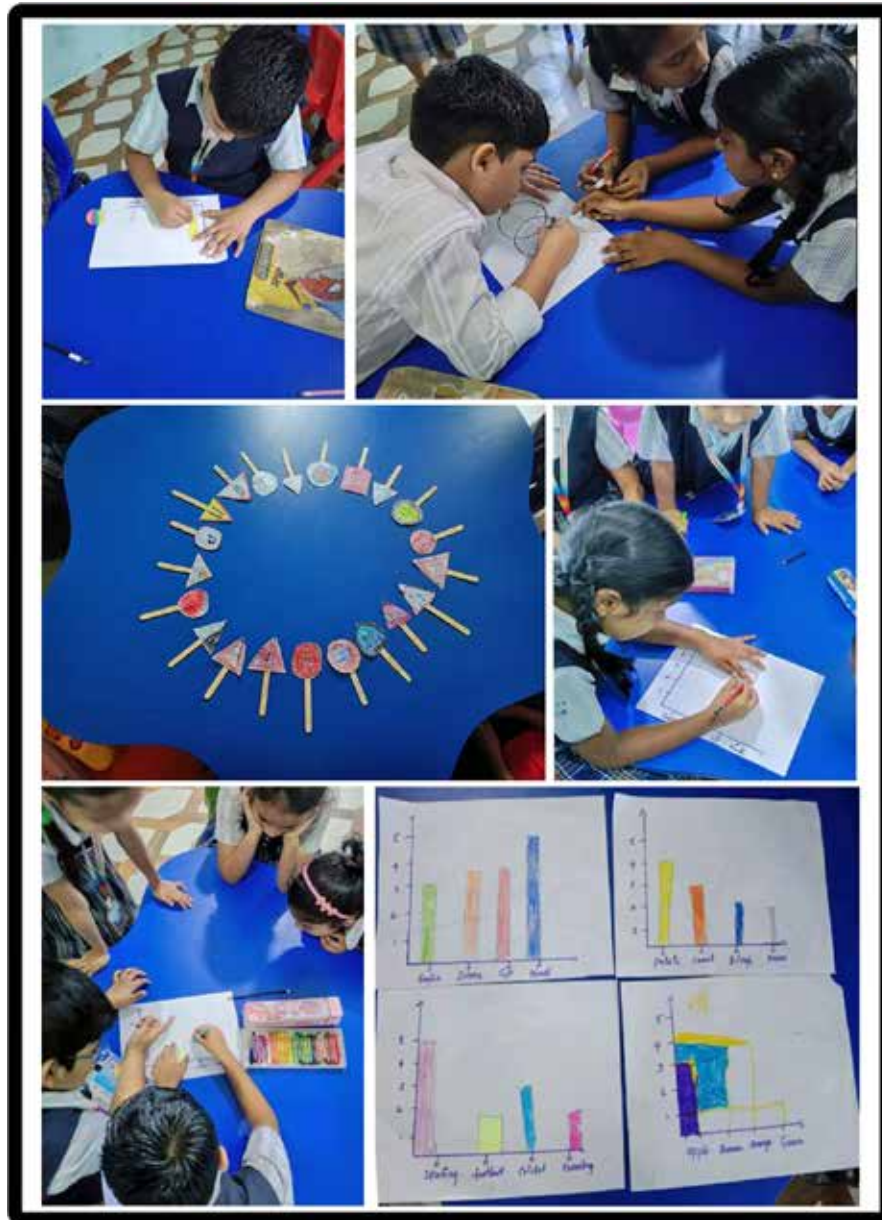
Parveen Banu

When I first saw the words ‘*global perspectives*’ on my timetable, I paused and asked myself, “What exactly is this subject?”

Many of us, even today, might not know much about it. It isn’t one of those familiar school subjects like science, English, or math, which we all have studied. Yet, once you begin to understand it, you can’t help but fall in love with it, because it connects all the other subjects and turns them into meaningful experiences.

I began my teaching journey in a school that follows the Cambridge curriculum, where I was introduced to this unfamiliar subject. Even during my Master’s in Education from Azim Premji University, where I explored child development, pedagogy, and learning theories, I did not come across a subject like this. The name itself made me curious. What could *global perspectives* possibly mean for such young learners?

Through exploration and experience, I soon discovered that it is more than a subject. It is a way of thinking and learning that helps children see connections between their everyday lives and the wider world. According to the Cambridge Primary Global Perspectives Framework (Cambridge International, 2025), the course aims to develop skills such as research, analysis, evaluation, reflection, collaboration, and communication – skills that prepare children to think independently and work meaningfully with others.



Photos courtesy: Parveen Banu

At first, I wondered whether six and seven-year-olds could really develop these skills. But as the lessons unfolded, I realized that they absolutely could, when learning is brought down to their level through activities, stories, and hands-on experiences. Educational research consistently supports this idea: when children learn through real-life engagement and practical exploration, their curiosity deepens, and their communication and problem-solving abilities grow (Westeam Ahead, 2025).

For example, while exploring “What is technology?”, we began by listing items such as mobile phones, TVs, and laptops. Then I asked, “Do all games need technology?” That one question changed the discussion completely. Soon, the class was comparing skipping ropes and footballs with video games, thinking critically, sharing ideas, and even debating their choices. Inquiry had begun.

Global perspectives also blurred the lines between subjects. While discussing data collection, we created pictograms and bar graphs to record our favourite fruits, an effortless link to math. When we spoke about recycling and waste management, science and environmental awareness naturally emerged. Through topics such as signboards, food, and emotions, we strengthened English vocabulary and social and emotional learning.

Over time, my classroom filled up with posters, bar graphs, mind maps, and clay models. My students created murals about teamwork, designed charts on sustainable travel, and constructed simple 3D displays to raise awareness about caring for the Earth. Each activity became an opportunity for collaboration and creativity. Studies such as those shared by CPD Singapore (2025) highlight that integrating global perspectives in early education fosters empathy, critical thinking, and an understanding of how personal actions connect to broader global issues, something I witnessed daily in my classroom.



What surprised me most was how global perspectives changed my own definition of “skills.” Earlier, I thought of skills as dancing, drawing, or coding. This subject helped me see that asking questions, investigating, analyzing, and working in a team are also vital life skills, and that even young children can practise them meaningfully.

I used to associate “research” with university projects, but in my classroom, research began with a simple question and child-led discovery. When my students asked, “How do we help at home?” or “Where does our food come from?” they were, in their own small way, conducting research, collecting information, observing, and reflecting before concluding. Watching them find answers through play and dialogue changed how I viewed learning itself.



In the end, global perspectives reshaped not only how my students learn, but how I see learning itself. As children questioned, explored, and connected their everyday experiences to the wider world, I too learned to step back, listen more, and trust the power of curiosity. I rediscovered that teaching is not about delivering answers, but about growing alongside learners. Global perspectives transformed my classroom into a space of connection, reflection, and purpose, reminding both my students and me that real learning happens when we make sense of the world together.

Acknowledgment: I am deeply grateful to my school for introducing me to global perspectives and trusting me to teach it to young learners. This opportunity allowed me to grow not only as an educator but also as a learner, continually reflecting, adapting, and evolving alongside my students.

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Parveen Banu is a primary school teacher with experience in the Cambridge curriculum. She is passionate about inquiry-based learning, global perspectives, and creating meaningful learning experiences for young children. The author can be reached at [<parveen7294banu@gmail.com>](mailto:parveen7294banu@gmail.com).

Of course, teaching multiple sections was not always easy. Repeating the same activity eight times a week tested my creativity and patience. Yet, each group brought fresh energy and new ideas. One of the highlights was our progression-test projects: grade 1 created posters on “Where does our food come from?”, while grade 2 explored “How can our journey to school be sustainable?” The joy extended beyond the classroom; parents reported that these topics sparked family discussions and even weekend field trips to farms and factories.

That moment reaffirmed my belief that global perspectives is not confined to textbooks. It connects children to the real world and helps them understand that their actions matter, regardless of how small they are. It turns lessons into life experiences and teachers into lifelong learners.

The public and private divide

Prakash Iyer

Ira: We have been talking about diversity in India and the urgent need to educate children to get to know, understand, and see the people around them as fellow citizens, and also to deal with conflicts that may come up. Aristotle's idea that even anger towards others takes a different form when we realize we are bound together by a common good is compelling.

In order to encourage and conserve diversity, the Constitution allows special rights to minorities to start their own schools. At the same time, the common good is also emphasized. There is a tension between the two objectives – highlighting differences between groups of people, and at the same time, promoting fraternity through the notion of the common good of the nation. Wouldn't it be simpler for the Constitution to focus on the common good through common laws that apply to everyone and leave their private affairs like religion, language, etc., to the groups to figure out themselves?

Anubhuti: I get your point. You are saying that the Constitution should draw a line between the public and the private and regulate only the public part of life. But the problem is this line between the public and private is not easy to draw. Many public issues include concerns that one might consider are private and vice versa. For instance, religion governs the way we think, live our lives, and also has implications on Fundamental Rights, which are public in nature.

The British had realized this and had enacted many laws governing property, but they had to make sure that these laws did not infringe on religion. They "enacted the Registration Act, the Limitation Act, the Civil Procedure Code (*all related to property ownership and transfer*), the Criminal Procedure Code, the Penal Code, the Evidence Act (*all related to criminal law*), the Transfer of Property Act, the Sarda Act (*legalizing marriageable age, thus criminalizing child marriages*) and various other Acts. ...gradually as occasion arose and they were intended to make the laws uniform although they clash with the personal laws of a particular community." The British excluded laws governing marriage and inheritance from these common laws, because "it will be difficult at this stage of our society to ask the people to give up their ideas of marriage, which are associated with

religious institutions in many communities. The laws of inheritance are also supposed to be the result of religious injunctions."ⁱ

The British had understood that common laws that interfere with religions would be perceived as favouring one community over another. That is why their laws focussed on property and taxes and registration of inheritance alone. The Constituent Assembly did something similar, in that they let religious beliefs decide inheritance and property sharing norms, and drafted laws on property registration alone. They left the development of a uniform civil code to future generations by adding it to the Directive Principles of State Policy, rather than rights.

No one seems to have disagreed on this; but the women in the Assembly did not agree since in the context of marriages, inheritance, and property, most popular religions in India are unfair towards women."ⁱⁱ

Ira: We did talk at length about the Right to Freedom of Speech and Expression, and how it has to be regulated by national security and public order. What was so conflicting in Right to Religion?

Anubhuti: Everyone agreed that the Right to Practice and Profess a Religion should be a Fundamental Right and that the Constitution should not only allow, but also encourage this right. But major disagreement and debates arose over making the Right to Propagate religions a Fundamental Right.

Tajamul Hussain was vociferously against this and argued that "...religion is a private affair between oneself and his Creator. It has nothing to do with others. My religion is my own belief, and your religion, Sir, is your own belief. Why should you interfere with my religion, and why should I interfere with your religion? Religion is only a means for the attainment of one's salvation. Supposing I honestly believe that I will attain salvation according to my way of thinking, and according to my religion, and

i. <https://www.constitutionofindia.net/debates/23-nov-1948/#99934>

ii. <https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5XK89zSgK8o> [from 32:08 onwards for opinions of Rajkumari Amrit Kaur and Hansa Mehta, who were against this treatment of family/marriage law]

you Sir, honestly believe that you will attain salvation according to your way, then why should I ask you to attain salvation according to my way, or why should you ask me to attain salvation according to your way? If you accept this proposition, then why propagate religion?"ⁱⁱⁱ Lokanath Mishra concurred with this opinion and insisted that there is no constitution in the world that makes propagating one's religion a fundamental right. He said that if we are making the right to propagate religion a fundamental right, we should make anti-religious propaganda also a fundamental right like the then Soviet Union had done.^{iv}

They had a few other supporters like H V Kamath, who said the state should not be secular in the absolute sense of the term; rather the state should encourage spiritual education that is not attached to any organized religion. He said that they should add a clause in the Constitution that said, "The State shall do all in its power to impart spiritual training and spiritual instruction to the citizens of the Union."^v

Ira: People of all religions were opposed to not making propagating a religion a fundamental right. The Constituent Assembly had thought of the public-private divide as well.

iii. <https://www.constitutionofindia.net/debates/03-dec-1948/#93196>
iv. <https://www.constitutionofindia.net/debates/06-dec-1948/#93257>
v. <https://www.constitutionofindia.net/debates/06-dec-1948/#93264>

Anubhuti: Yes, like a dear friend says, many members of the Constituent Assembly could be called established lawyers and political philosophers, as good as the best academics we know today.

There were many others who also argued for the right to propagate religion to be a fundamental right. For instance, Lakshmi Kanta Maitra argued that there were many instances of proselytizing religions not causing any harm and instead assimilating religious practices into the Indian culture.

K T Shah's response to this issue is notable. He said, "I have no quarrel with the right that anybody professing any particular form of belief should be at liberty, in this Liberal State, to place the benefits or beauties of his particular form of worship before others. My only condition...is that this freedom should not be abused In places or institutions, where people of tender age or those suffering from any bodily or mental infirmity, are exposed to undue influence, they are liable to be influenced more by the personality of those in authority above them than by the inherent advantages and unquestionable reasoning in favour of a particular religion, and as such result in conversion. That is not a genuine change of opinion but is the result of undue influence that ought to be stopped.

I have no quarrel at all with those who would change their opinion after full and mature consideration of such material as may be available to them regarding



the beliefs that they inherit from their parents. Most of the religious beliefs in this world are not – may I say without any offence – a matter of reasoned conviction; they are an acquired habit or an inherited prejudice which may not stand the strain of conviction on the opposite side, or reasoning on the controverting side. Accordingly, anybody who desires the mind of the public to be alert free from prejudice and open to conviction, will not object to permitting such freedom of propaganda that may result in conversion.”^{vi}

See how keen and sharp his argument is? He is arguing on the basis that all humans have rational autonomy and that propagation of religion is usually not limited to reason but also includes faith. We need to be careful about what we mean when we say ‘right to propagate’ and we should limit this right and ensure that it is not abused by the strong over the weak, insecure, and mentally infirm. Shah insisted that proselytizing should only be allowed in public places, not in “school or a college, in an hospital or asylum, those who are set in authority as teacher or preacher, physician, guardian or nurse,” where people are in peculiar positions of authority and could exercise undue influence on others.”^{vii}

K Santhanam argued further that the Constitution should limit religious propaganda and disallow *mass conversions* since they are inevitably a result of large financing and must be targeting harmony in society – “if any attempt is made by one religious community or another to have mass conversions through undue influence either by money or by pressure or by other means, the State has every right to regulate such activity. Therefore, I submit to you that this article, as it is, is not so much an article ensuring freedom, but toleration – toleration for all, irrespective of the religious practice or profession.”^{viii} This made it clear that the state should be secular – not favour one religion over another – which led to the cultural and educational rights being fundamental but with clear restrictions that government aided schools should not impose any particular religion.

Ira: Article 28 of the Constitution clarifies this and additionally protects individual rights by saying that learners are not required to participate in any religious instruction.

Anubhuti: Yes. K T Shah further argued that religious organizations also have *secular* activities like financial and administrative, which should be regulated and
vi. <https://www.constitutionofindia.net/debates/03-dec-1948/#93222>
vii. Lakshmi Kant Maitra also agreed with K T Shah on this. His argument had examples of instances of other religions who propagated their religion but also assimilated into Indian culture.
viii. <https://www.constitutionofindia.net/debates/06-dec-1948/#93346>

controlled, and that any misuse of funds should be *strictly prohibited*. He was very firm on this separation of religious and non-religious activities, both of which do happen in religious organizations.

T T Krishnamachari concurred with K T Shah and K Santhanam and had an additional view that this right should be universal and not applicable only to some religions. That will ensure that there is no conflict between religions or the Constitution is not accused of favouritism. He actually gave the example of Arya Samajists who were doing a different kind of conversion within Hinduism – of reforming the religion itself.

Ira: That is why we have a separate section in the Constitution – Articles 25 to 30 - on the Right to Freedom of Religion and Cultural and Educational Rights; they had to accommodate all these nuances.

Anubhuti: K T Shah pointed out that in terms of reform, the Constitution is only insisting on Hindu places of worship to be open to all irrespective of caste or sex. Why should this not be extended to all religions?

Coming back to your original question about one common law governing all religions – that was debated at length and most people were against the idea. They found it hard to have a common law governing marriages and family, simply because these practices, rituals, and traditions are an integral part of any religion. In fact, they argued that it would be difficult to identify a common law governing all religions, without it being perceived as favouritism towards one religion or another.

Instead, the general agreement was that all religion-based civil laws should be retained – like the British had done – and instead one should allow reform of marriage laws if their practices are seen to be violating any Fundamental Rights.

Ira: This brings us back to K T Shah’s argument on the secular practices related to religions and the associated risks.

Anubhuti: Or like Rajeev Bhargava famously said, the Indian Constitution is not secular in the western way; rather it maintains a *principled distance from religion*. And I would add that it uses the Fundamental Rights as the basis for that principled distance.

Prakash Iyer teaches Philosophy of Education, Moral and Political Philosophy, and Curriculum Theory at Azim Premji University, Bengaluru. The author can be reached at <prakash.iyer@apu.edu.in>.

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